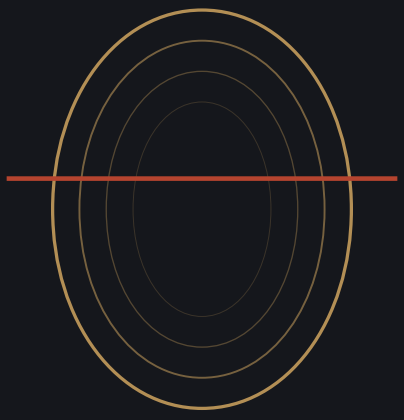
A DISSERTATION



EFFACEMENT

Prosopocide, Diaphanocracy, and the Second Parricide
in Alfred Bester's *The Demolished Man*

MMXXVI

For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:12

Thou canst not see my face: for there shall no man see me, and live.

EXODUS 33:20

ABSTRACT

This dissertation proposes that Alfred Bester's *The Demolished Man* (serialized in *Galaxy Science Fiction*, January–March 1952; Shasta, 1953), the inaugural recipient of the Hugo Award for Best Novel, is not the ingenious popularization of mid-century Freudianism that its reception has largely taken it to be, but the founding fable of a political form this study names *diaphanocracy*: an order whose security, legitimacy, and libidinal cohesion rest upon the transparency of minds. Reconstructing the novel's intellectual sources—Freud's metapsychology, his anthropology of primal parricide, and his neglected papers on thought-transference; Wilhelm Reich's characterology and Theodor Reik's criminology of confession; the parapsychological lineage descending from Frederic Myers to J. B. Rhine; the cybernetic and information-theoretic paradigms of Wiener and Shannon; and the American rehabilitative ideal at its juridical zenith—and situating the novel within a comparative archive that extends from Sophocles, Plato, and Paul through Dostoevsky, Poe, Stevenson, Kafka, and Zamyatin to Stapledon, Sturgeon, Clarke, Wyndham, Lem, Dick, and Le Guin, the dissertation argues that the novel's three constitutive acts—Ben Reich's parricide, the telepathic supersession of the face as the interface of social life, and the juridical-therapeutic rite of Demolition—compose a single economy of effacement, here termed *prosopocide*.

At the center of that economy stands the Man With No Face, which the dissertation submits to a fourfold exegesis on the medieval model (literal, allegorical, tropological, anagogical), demonstrating that the figure condenses the foreclosed paternal name, the formless sovereignty of a police that sees everything, the superego as interior garrison, and the deferred Pauline promise of knowing "face to face." From this exegesis the study derives a general proposition, *the law of the opaque remainder*: every advance in the transparency of minds displaces opacity from content (intention) to form (genealogy, structure, relation), whence it returns as crime without a knowable author. The novel's apparent resolution—the communal "mass cathexis" and the bloodless unmaking and reconstruction of the criminal person—is shown to repeat Freud's totemic murder in inverted, therapeutic form (*the second parricide*), through which a telepathic fraternity becomes the new father of the capitalist dynasty it supplants, assuming custody of both of the murdered patriarch's children. The dissertation concludes that Bester's novel, against its own explicit utopianism, articulates the first systematic image of the *post-facial condition*—the regime of facial recognition, predictive policing, neural decoding, and asymmetrical platform transparency now in formation—and that its buried normative claim is a *right to the face*: the ethical opacity without which punishment, love, and personhood cease to be intelligible.

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INTRODUCTION



The Last Murder

In the New York of 2301 imagined by Alfred Bester, no premeditated murder has succeeded in seventy-nine years. The achievement belongs to the Esper Guild, a professional corporation of telepaths stratified into three classes—the Third reading the surface of consciousness, the Second the preconscious, the First the deepest strata of the unconscious, in a census the novel puts at roughly a hundred thousand, ten thousand, and fewer than a thousand members respectively (DM ch. 1, pp. 19–20)—whose diffusion through every institution of public life has rendered homicidal intention legible before it can become act. After a one-page prologue that sets the whole story beneath what it calls the infinite Eye of God, the novel opens on the eve of the crime that this order has made impossible: Ben Reich, master of the cartel Monarch Utilities & Resources, resolves to kill Craye D'Courtney, head of the rival cartel that threatens Monarch with ruin, and does so by firing a water-filled gelatin capsule from an antique knife-pistol through the old man's mouth. The crime succeeds in the narrow sense that it is committed; it fails, as Lincoln Powell, Prefect of the Police Psychotic Division and Esper of the First Class, demonstrates over the ensuing pursuit, in every other sense. Yet the decisive revelation of the novel is neither the identity of the murderer, which Powell intuits almost at once, nor the method, which forensic ingenuity reconstructs, but the motive—which the murderer himself does not possess. D'Courtney, it emerges, had accepted the merger whose rejection Reich claims to have avenged; he was, moreover, Reich's unacknowledged father. The first murder in eight decades is a parricide, and it was possible only because its true motive was invisible to the very mind that the Guild's transparency was supposed to expose.

This paradox is the generative kernel of the present study. A society that has abolished the privacy of intention has not thereby abolished opacity; it has relocated it. What can no longer hide in the conscious mind takes refuge in the structure that produced that mind—in genealogy, in the family, in the forms of relation that precede and exceed any content a telepath could read. The novel's real subject, I shall argue, is that relocation: the migration of the unknowable from the inside of persons to the space between them, and the forms of violence, law, and love that a transparent society invents in order to govern what it still cannot see.

The critical reception of *The Demolished Man* has, by and large, approached the novel through three doors. The genre-historical approach honors it as the inaugural Hugo laureate (1953), as the work that fused the detective story and science fiction into the futurological police procedural, and as the flagship of the psychological and sociological program that H. L. Gold's *Galaxy* opposed to the engineering ethos of John W. Campbell's *Astounding*. The formal approach admires its kinetic prose and typographic audacity—the interlaced telepathic conversations, the ampersands and at-signs of its proper names, the commercial jingle that Reich installs in his own head as a shield against probing—and identifies in it the proleptic grammar of cyberpunk. The psychoanalytic approach, finally, recognizes the novel's systematic deployment of Freudian topography and either credits Bester with a sophisticated dramatization of the unconscious or regrets a "textbook" Freudianism that dates the book as surely as its punch-card prosecution computer. The novel's Freudianism is, in fact, technical rather than atmospheric: it names the id and the superego, borrows the economic term cathexis for its climactic rite, and diagnoses its victim with a defusion of the Life and Death Instincts, both of which, a First Class Esper explains, seek Nirvana by opposite routes (DM chs. 4, 11, 17). Readers of every persuasion have registered, with justified unease, the sexual politics of a plot in which the murdered man's daughter, regressed to infancy by trauma and therapy, grows up again in the detective's house and falls in love with him.

These approaches share an unexamined premise: that the novel's Freudianism is its content. The present dissertation reverses that premise. The Freudian apparatus of *The Demolished Man* is its manifest content; its latent content is political-theological. Beneath the case history of a parricide lies an allegory of succession, in which sovereignty passes from the capitalist dynasty—Reich's company is named Monarch, and his surname is the German word for empire—to a telepathic commons that inherits the dead patriarch's children. Beneath the detective plot lies an epistemology of the face, tracing the endpoint of a centuries-long tradition in which guilt was read off physiognomy. And beneath the penal utopia of Demolition—a punishment that annihilates the person while preserving the body and its energies for social use—lies a secularized soteri-

ology of the old and new man, a theodicy of transparency that undertakes to justify the ways of a seeing community to the remainder it cannot see.

The method adopted here is constellational in the sense Walter Benjamin and Theodor W. Adorno gave the term: the novel is read not as the expression of a single doctrine but as the point at which several genealogies intersect and illuminate one another—psychoanalysis and parapsychology, criminology and cybernetics, Pauline theology and the political economy of information, the detective story and the philosophical novel of guilt. It is also, more specifically, *prosopological*. Marcel Mauss's celebrated lecture on the category of the person (1938) traced the career of the Latin *persona* from the ritual mask through the juridical person of Roman law to the moral and psychological self of modernity; the Greek *prosōpon* already joined face, mask, and role in a single word. The person, in the Western tradition, was born as a face. A theory of the face is therefore a theory of personhood, and a fiction that abolishes faces—as Bester's does, by making them epistemically superfluous—is necessarily a fiction about the unmaking and remaking of persons. That Bester's working title was the exclamatory *Demolition!*, abandoned at Gold's urging for the passive participle that names the procedure's object rather than its act, is itself an index of the shift the novel stages: from the sovereign deed to the subject that a therapeutic power produces.

Five concepts organize the argument. *Diaphanocracy* (from the Greek *diaphanēs*, transparent) designates a political order grounded in the legibility of minds. It is distinct from Benthamite and Foucauldian panopticism, which renders bodies visible in order to induce self-discipline, because it renders intentions legible and so operates prior to action; and it is distinct from the "transparency society" diagnosed by Byung-Chul Han, because Bester's transparency is asymmetrical—Espers read, normals are read—and libidinally charged, organized by an ethic of discretion and love rather than of exposure. *Prosopocide* names the destruction of the face as interface and as persona, which the novel enacts in three modalities: criminal (Reich fires through the mouth of a father whom cancer of the throat had already deprived of speech), structural (telepathy renders the face superfluous as the medium through which one mind encounters another), and juridical (Demolition erases the person in order to rebuild it). *The law of the opaque remainder* holds that opacity is conserved under transparency, migrating from content to form. *The second parricide* designates the Esper fraternity's collective unmaking of the parricidal son, an inversion of the primal murder of Freud's *Totem and Taboo* through which the commons installs itself as the new father. *The post-facial condition*, finally, names the historical regime in which the face ceases to mediate access to the person, replaced by direct biometric, behavioral, and neural inscription. Two subsidiary terms complete the apparatus: *re-facement*, the constructive phase of Demolition, in which a polity that has abolished faces must manufacture persons; and the

right to the face, the normative claim the novel makes against its own explicit utopianism.

The argument unfolds in eight chapters. Chapter One reconstructs the conjuncture of 1950–1953 in which four discourses of transparency—American psychoanalysis at its apogee, Rhinean parapsychology, Wienerian cybernetics, and the Cold War inquisition of interiority—converged on Bester's desk, and recovers Freud's own speculations on thought-transference as the hidden origin of the novel's fusion of telepathy and the unconscious. Chapter Two situates the novel at the terminus of the physiognomic history of detection, from Lavater and Lombroso to Dupin and Holmes, and reads the prosecution computer Old Man Mose and the misread cipher WWHG as the novel's interrogation of *mens rea*. Chapter Three places Reich beside Oedipus, Hamlet, and the Karamazovs as the fourth term in Freud's canon of parricide and develops the concept of the second parricide. Chapter Four theorizes diaphanocracy as political theology and political economy, from Locke's property in the person to Hayek's knowledge problem. Chapter Five examines Demolition against the philosophy of punishment from Plato to Foucault and the therapeutic jurisprudence of the 1950s. Chapter Six, the core of the dissertation, submits the Man With No Face to a fourfold exegesis. Chapter Seven sets the novel within the comparative archive of speculative and philosophical fiction. Chapter Eight turns to form, reading Bester's typography as the novel's own face. A Conclusion condenses the argument into theses on the post-facial condition. Because the pagination of *The Demolished Man* varies widely across its many editions, references give chapter and page in the 1978 Pocket Books printing (cited as DM), against whose full text every reading below has been checked.

CHAPTER

1

Genealogies of Transparency

Bester, Galaxy, *and the Conjuncture of 1950–1953*

The Demolished Man was written at the precise historical moment when four discourses of transparency—psychoanalytic, parapsychological, cybernetic, and political-inquisitorial—converged in American culture, and its originality consists less in any single idea than in the rigor with which it made them answer to one another. This chapter reconstructs that conjuncture and recovers, within Freud's own work, the hidden warrant for the novel's most apparently pulp-eclectic gesture: the fusion of telepathy with the unconscious.

1.1 *Apprenticeship in the Invisible*

Alfred Bester (1913–1987), born in Manhattan and educated at the University of Pennsylvania, entered science fiction in 1939 with "The Broken Axiom" in *Thrilling Wonder Stories*, but his decisive apprenticeship lay elsewhere. Through the 1940s he wrote for comic books—the Green Lantern oath is commonly credited to him—and for radio drama, including *Nick Carter, Master Detective*, *Charlie Chan*, and *The Shadow*. The last deserves more weight than biographical notice usually affords it. The Shadow was a detective whose epistemic privilege was immediate knowledge of the evil concealed in human hearts and whose tactical privilege was the power to cloud other minds so that he could not be seen. *The Demolished Man* divides these two powers between antagonists: Powell inherits the knowledge of hearts, Reich the art of mental invisibility. The novel's founding opposition is thus already present, fused in a single figure, in the radio serials on which Bester learned to plot.

His return to science fiction at the decade's turn announced its psychoanalytic program openly. "Oddy and Id" (1950) concerns a young man whose unconscious bends probability around him and whose teachers resolve to harness this impersonal luck for the improvement of the world, only to discover that the id is indifferent to their ethics. The story is a rehearsal for the novel's central wager—that a dangerous psychic energy might be captured and redirected for social ends—and for its central anxiety, that such energy has its own designs. Serialized in *Galaxy Science Fiction* from January to March 1952 and published in book form by Shasta in 1953, *The Demolished Man* received the first Hugo Award for Best Novel at that year's World Science Fiction Convention in Philadelphia. Its working title, *Demolition!*, was abandoned at the urging of the magazine's editor, H. L. Gold, to whom the novel is dedicated.

1.2 Galaxy *against* Astounding*: The Editorial Politics of the Psyche*

Gold founded *Galaxy* in October 1950 as a deliberate counter-program to John W. Campbell's *Astounding*, privileging psychological interiority, social satire, and the speculative extrapolation of institutions over the engineering problem-story. The contrast was sharpest on the terrain of the mind itself. In May 1950 *Astounding* had published L. Ron Hubbard's founding exposition of Dianetics, a pseudo-therapy promising, through the "auditing" of traumatic engrams down to the prenatal, the production of a "Clear" purged of the past; Campbell subsequently championed "psionics" as a frontier of engineering. *The Demolished Man* may be read as *Galaxy*'s Freudian rejoinder. Its two regressive therapies—the Déjà Éprouvé Series, which returns Barbara D'Courtney to infancy and allows her personality to grow again over three weeks, and Demolition, which erases Reich's memories while preserving consciousness and the capacity for rebirth—realize the Dianetic fantasy of total psychic recomposition, but they relocate it within a credentialed guild bound by an oath and within a Freudian topography that refuses the promise of a past simply deleted.

The novel's immediate textual milieu confirms the magazine's coherence as an intellectual formation. *Galaxy* had published Ray Bradbury's "The Fireman" (February 1951), the seed of *Fahrenheit 451*; it serialized Frederik Pohl and C. M. Kornbluth's "Gravy Planet" (June–August 1952), the corporate-sovereignty satire later issued as *The Space Merchants*; it printed Theodore Sturgeon's "Baby Is Three" (October 1952), a novella cast as a psychoanalytic session and the nucleus of *More Than Human*; and it would serialize Isaac Asimov's *The Caves of Steel* (October–December 1953), Asimov's own fusion of the detective plot with speculative sociology. The corporation as polity, the analytic session as narrative form, and the detective story as a vehicle of social speculation were thus the house idioms in which Bester's novel was conceived. Gold's notoriously interventionist editing, finally, offers a rhyme that is more than anecdotal: a magazine that regularly took manuscripts apart and rebuilt them around the energies

it judged salvageable published a novel whose penal ideal is precisely the dismantling of a person and the conservation of his force. The novel returns the compliment. In a Spaceland cemetery, a replica cathedral sells tickets to robot-acted dramas of the gods, from Moses on Sinai to the unveiling of the True and Only God Galaxy (DM ch. 12, p. 156)—a joke at the expense of commodified religion, and very probably at the expense of the magazine.

1.3 *Four Discourses of Transparency*

The first discourse is psychoanalytic. By the early 1950s American psychoanalysis had attained an institutional, therapeutic, and cultural hegemony unmatched anywhere in the world. Ego psychology, systematized by Heinz Hartmann, Ernst Kris, and Rudolph Loewenstein, had reoriented Freud's tragic metapsychology toward adaptation; Karl Menninger's clinic in Topeka had made the psychiatrist a national authority; and Hollywood had naturalized the analytic plot in films such as *Lady in the Dark* (1944) and Alfred Hitchcock's *Spellbound* (1945), in which an amnesiac who believes himself guilty of a childhood fratricide is cleared when a psychoanalyst decodes his dream and the true murderer is unmasked. *Spellbound* is the nearest cinematic ancestor of Bester's novel: a murder solved by dream interpretation, a guilt that precedes and exceeds any act. The juridical expression of this hegemony arrived the year after the novel's book publication, when *Durham v. United States* (1954) held that an accused is not criminally responsible if the unlawful act was the product of mental disease or defect—the high-water mark of the attempt to translate the moral vocabulary of guilt into the clinical vocabulary of pathology, abandoned by the same court in *United States v. Brawner* (1972). Philip Rieff would soon name the anthropological type this culture produced: "psychological man," successor to the religious and economic men of earlier epochs (Rieff 1959). *The Demolished Man* dramatizes exactly that succession, for its antagonists are economic man (Reich) and psychological man (Powell).

The second discourse is parapsychological. The word *telepathy* was coined by Frederic W. H. Myers in 1882 within the Society for Psychical Research, and the late-Victorian invention of the concept, as Roger Luckhurst has shown, was entangled from the start with new communications technologies and with nascent theories of the subliminal self (Luckhurst 2002). J. B. Rhine's *Extra-Sensory Perception* (1934) supplied the acronym ESP from which Bester's "Esper" is a back-formation, and gave the phenomenon a laboratory, a statistics, and a public. Its reach is measured by a single concession: in "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950), Alan Turing listed extrasensory perception among the objections to his imitation game, remarked that "the statistical evidence, at least for telepathy, is overwhelming," and proposed seating the contestants in a "telepathy-proof room." The founding document of artificial intelligence thus juxtaposes the computing machine and the telepath exactly as Bester's novel does,

where the prosecution computer Old Man Mose and the Esper Guild divide between them the labor of establishing guilt.

The third discourse is cybernetic. Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948) and *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950), together with Claude Shannon's "A Mathematical Theory of Communication" (1948), recast mind, society, and machine as systems of messages exchanged across noisy channels. Bester's novel is saturated with this paradigm: the mind as signal, the Esper as receiver, Reich's commercial jingle as engineered noise injected into the channel to defeat reception, the coded telegram WWHG as a message whose decoding fails not through channel noise but through noise at the source, in the desire of the receiver. Old Man Mose, which processes the evidence of motive, method, and opportunity on punched cards and returns a probability of conviction, is the juridical avatar of the Leibnizian dream of resolving disputes by calculation.

The fourth discourse is political-inquisitorial. The novel was composed in the years of Senator Joseph McCarthy's Wheeling speech (February 1950), of the federal loyalty-security program inaugurated by Executive Order 9835 (1947), and of the journalist Edward Hunter's introduction of "brain-washing" into English (September 1950; *Brain-Washing in Red China*, 1951). The state's demand to know what citizens believe, and the terror that an enemy might rewrite what they believe, were the twin political forms of a culture newly obsessed with interiority. Julius and Ethel Rosenberg, convicted in 1951 of conspiring to pass atomic secrets to the Soviet Union, were executed by the federal government in the electric chair at Sing Sing in June 1953, the year of the novel's book publication. Against this background *The Demolished Man* offers a liberal reassurance whose ambivalence will occupy much of this dissertation: interiority will indeed be known, but by physicians of the mind bound by a professional pledge rather than by senators; secrets will indeed become impossible, but the state that abolishes them will never kill.

1.4 *Freud's Telepathy: The Hidden Origin*

The fusion of telepathy and psychoanalysis in *The Demolished Man* has usually been treated as the opportunism of a genre writer combining two fashionable vocabularies. It is, on the contrary, the activation of a possibility latent within metapsychology itself. Freud returned repeatedly to thought-transference: in "Psycho-Analysis and Telepathy" (written 1921, published 1941), in "Dreams and Telepathy" (1922), and in the lecture "Dreams and Occultism" (1933), where he granted the phenomenon a guarded credence and ventured a phylogenetic hypothesis—that direct psychical transference may be the archaic means by which individuals once understood one another, displaced in the course of development by communication through signs, yet perhaps still operative in the coordinated life of insect communities and resurgent in the passions of

crowds. His private correspondence with Ernest Jones records the depth of this commitment and the anxiety it provoked in a movement that feared association with the occult.

The theoretical consequences are considerable. Freud observed that telepathic messages, when they arrive, arrive through the unconscious and surface in dreams; the unconscious is thus not only what telepathy reads but the medium through which it travels. Bester's First Class Espers, who read precisely the unconscious wishes Freud thought transferable, are therefore not a fantastic supplement to psychoanalysis but its speculative completion, and the Guild's climactic "mass cathexis"—the pooling of every Esper's psychic energy through a single channel—realizes the archaic, collective telepathy Freud glimpsed in insect states and crowds. Jacques Derrida's essay "Telepathy" (1981) read Freud's texts on the subject as an anxious meditation on destination and the misdelivered message; Nicholas Royle (1991) and Pamela Thurschwell (2001) have since demonstrated how deeply telepathic fantasy structures modern narrative. *The Demolished Man*, whose plot turns on a misdelivered message, belongs at the center of that tradition rather than at its popular margin.

1.5 *The Onomastic Constellation*

The novel's names constitute a compressed allegory. *Ben Reich* joins the Hebrew *ben*, "son of," to the German *Reich*, "empire" or "realm"—the son of the realm, the unacknowledged heir—and the name sounded, seven years after 1945, as the name of the Third Reich, the National Socialist state that had murdered some six million European Jews before its destruction that year; a writer of Jewish descent gave that word to the character in his novel who arrogates the sovereign right to kill. The novel plants the theme of the heir in its first scene: free-associating on his analyst's couch, Reich lets slip "dort" for "bort," and the analyst reads "Heir" in the "air" of his dream (DM ch. 1, pp. 14–15). He governs a company called Monarch. His victim and father bears a courtly name, D'Courtney; his adversary bears the name of the president who preserved a union and emancipated its bondsmen, Lincoln. The prosecution computer is Old Man Mose, the lawgiver reduced to an oracle of punched cards. Augustus Tate, the corrupt First Class Esper whom Reich purchases with the promise of the presidency of a restructured Guild, carries an imperial praenomen; Jerry Church, the Esper expelled from the Guild for earlier services to Reich, is the novel's excommunicate. Barbara recalls the Greek *barbaros*, the one outside the language—here, apparently, outside the telepathic speech of the Guild, though the denouement will reveal her latent membership. The fortune-telling den in which Barbara is found catatonic is kept by Chooka Frood, whose surname is a near-homophone of Freud's and whom Powell, watching her preside over a cellar of singing crystal, likens to a vulgar Medusa, Freud's own em-

blem of the terrifying face (DM ch. 9, p. 113): the unconscious, in this topography, is a disreputable house of fortunes where the traumatized witness lies hidden.

Two further resonances, whether or not Bester intended them, belong to the constellation because the novel's logic summons them. The first is Wilhelm Reich, whose *Charakteranalyse* (1933; English 1945, enlarged 1949) theorized "character armor," the rigid defensive structure by which a personality protects itself against the exposure of its impulses, and whose energetic conception of libido made him, by the late 1940s, a notorious figure in American intellectual journalism; that notoriety ended, as Chapter Five records, in a federal prison and in the burning of his publications under government supervision in 1956. Ben Reich's jingle is character armor in its purest form—a defensive structure installed on the surface of the mind—and the mass cathexis that finally breaches it is conceived in frankly energetic terms. The second is Theodor Reik, whose *Geständniszwang und Strafbedürfnis* (1925) and *Der unbekannte Mörder* (1932) argued that the criminal is driven by an unconscious compulsion to confess and an unconscious need for punishment, which betray him through slips and self-destructive acts. Ben Reich is caught when he lets slip that the fleeing Barbara was naked, a detail only the murderer could know; and the assassination attempts that pursue him through the second half of the novel are revealed to be his own, executed in somnambulistic fugues by a conscience bent on his destruction. Reich, Reik, Reich: empire, armor, confession. The name of Bester's protagonist is the point at which the novel's political, characterological, and criminological axes cross.

CHAPTER

2

Old Man Mose and the Purloined Motive

Detection, Physiognomy, and the Limits of Mens Rea

The detective story was, from its inception, a sublimated fiction of telepathy whose medium was the face; *The Demolished Man* completes the genre by removing the medium, and discovers that what lies behind the face is not the criminal's secret but a secret the criminal does not possess. This chapter traces that completion through the inverted detective form, the physiognomic episteme, the juridical machinery of motive, and the misread cipher on which the novel's plot pivots.

2.1 *The Inverted Detective and the Psychological Duel*

Bester's novel belongs formally to the "inverted" detective story invented by R. Austin Freeman in *The Singing Bone* (1912) and elevated by Francis Iles's *Malice Aforethought* (1931), in which the reader witnesses the crime and the suspense lies in the mechanism of exposure rather than the identity of the culprit. Its deeper model, however, is Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment* (1866), the archetype of the psychological duel between a murderer who believes himself exempt from common morality and an investigator who knows his guilt without being able to prove it. Porfiry Petrovich's circuitous, ironic, almost playful siege of Raskolnikov is the template for Powell's whimsical pursuit of Reich—a whimsy the novel personifies in Powell's own double, the compulsive teller of tall tales whom his colleagues call Dishonest Abe, inverting the proverbial honesty of the president whose name Powell bears—and Raskolnikov's theory of the

extraordinary man, entitled by his historical mission to step over blood, finds its capitalist translation in Reich's conviction that the magnitude of his enterprise exempts him from the Guild's order. The parallels extend to the dramaturgy of weakness: as Raskolnikov faints at the police station and wanders back to the scene of his crime, Reich, having found Powell in his sights at Chooka Frood's den, discovers that he cannot fire. In both novels the duel is erotic as much as agonistic, a relation of fascinated mutual recognition in which each antagonist is the other's truest reader. Bester names the attraction outright: at their first meeting "an unexpected chemotropism" draws the two men together, and Powell jokes that Reich's lawyer does not want him to love his client (DM ch. 6, pp. 75–76).

Yet Bester alters the duel's epistemological terms decisively. Porfiry must infer Raskolnikov's guilt from symptoms—a fainting fit, an article on crime, a nervous laugh. Powell perceives Reich's guilt directly, almost at once, and the whole difficulty of the novel lies in converting immediate knowledge into admissible proof. The inverted detective story here becomes a story about the incommensurability of two orders of knowing: the telepathic order, in which truth is intuited, and the juridical order, in which truth must be externalized, documented, and computed. The law of 2301 codifies the incommensurability: what an Esper perceives may guide an investigation, but it is inadmissible as evidence in court.

2.2 *The Physiognomic Episteme*

The detective's art has a prehistory in the science of faces. Johann Caspar Lavater's *Physiognomische Fragmente zur Beförderung der Menschenkenntnis und Menschenliebe* (1775–1778) promised to read character in the lineaments of the face, and its title binds the knowledge of human beings to the love of them in a single program. Cesare Lombroso's *L'uomo delinquente* (1876) converted physiognomy into a criminal anthropology of atavistic stigmata. Francis Galton's composite photographs of convicts (1879) superimposed many faces upon a single plate in pursuit of the criminal type, and produced instead an eerie, generalized countenance belonging to no one. Alphonse Bertillon's anthropometric system standardized the frontal and profile mugshot and codified the face into the verbal formulae of the *portrait parlé*. The trajectory is from the face as text to the face as code, and its terminus, in Galton's composite, is a face from which the individual has been subtracted.

The fictional detective inherited and sublimated this science. In "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" (1841), Poe's Dupin interrupts his companion's silent reverie to complete its thought aloud, having reconstructed the entire chain of association from a stumble, a glance at the paving stones, and a change of countenance. In "The Purloined Letter" (1844), he praises a schoolboy who wins at guessing games by shaping his own facial expression to match his opponent's and then observing what thoughts arise

within himself, as though the face were a channel through which another mind could be induced in one's own. Conan Doyle's Sherlock Holmes, in his magazine article "The Book of Life" in *A Study in Scarlet* (1887), claims that an observer trained in deduction can learn from a momentary expression or the twitch of a muscle "to fathom a man's inmost thoughts," and later astonishes Watson by following his unspoken reverie from his gaze and face. Detection, in its classical form, is telepathy disguised as inference, and its medium is the face. Bester's novel knows this lineage and stages its exhaustion. Powell describes his work by turning Sherlock into a verb (DM ch. 3, p. 36). He wishes he could read a corpse, like the old myth of photographing the retina of a dead eye—the optography of Wilhelm Kühne, who fixed images on the retina by bleaching rhodopsin, the very visual purple Reich's weapon destroys (ch. 6, p. 83)—and the Commissioner later floats the same myth as a press bluff to flush out the weapon's inventor (ch. 8, p. 105). Powell retires the physiognomic presumption in so many words when he remarks that people always expect villains to look villainous (ch. 10, p. 124). In 2301 the face can no longer testify in any case: plastic surgery gives a police spy new features, and Spaceland runs a resort of bandaged faces (chs. 8, 12, pp. 102, 155).

Bester's Espers dispense with the medium. They do not read faces; they read minds, and the face becomes epistemically superfluous—a surface that no longer conceals, because nothing behind it is concealed. This is the first sense in which the novel stages a prosopocide: not the destruction of a particular face but the obsolescence of the face as such in the economy of knowledge. Lavater's program survives intact—the Guild, too, joins the knowledge of persons to the love of them—but it has shed the flesh through which that knowledge once passed. And the consequence is a discovery the physiognomic tradition could never have made. The classical detective presumed that the criminal knew his own secret and that the face betrayed what the mind concealed. Bester's detective sees the mind directly and finds that its owner is deceived about it. The secret is not behind the face; it is behind the mind.

2.3 *Old Man Mose: The Letter That Killeth*

In Bester's 2301, no case may proceed to trial without the approval of Old Man Mose, the prosecution computer, which receives the evidence for motive, method, and opportunity and returns a probability of conviction. The triad is the classical architecture of criminal proof, and Mose is its mechanization: law as Leibnizian calculation, the legal-rational domination Max Weber described in *Economy and Society* (1922) perfected into a machine that cannot be bribed, flattered, or intimidated. The name, however, insists on a genealogy older than Weber, and the machine's full designation—the Mosaic Multiplex Prosecution Computor—makes it explicit. Bester gives the machine a body: Mose fills the circular wall of the District Attorney's office with multitudinous eyes, a speaker-cone mouth hanging open in astonishment at human stupidity, and typewriter

keys for hands (DM ch. 13, p. 167). The law that has no use for faces has a hundred eyes. Mose is Moses, the lawgiver of the Decalogue whose sixth commandment forbids killing, reduced to an oracle of punched cards. The Pauline formula is apposite: "the letter killeth, but the spirit giveth life" (2 Corinthians 3:6). Old Man Mose is the letter of the law, and the novel's governing contrast between the computer and the Guild reproduces Paul's opposition between the written code of Moses and the living spirit—an opposition that will return, in Chapter Five, in the contrast between the death penalty the novel's society has abolished and the Demolition it has instituted in its place.

The juridical crux of the novel is that the letter proves wiser than its servants. Old Man Mose first rejects Powell's case for insufficient documentation of a passion motive; persuaded to weigh the profit motive instead, it returns, on the assumption that the merger had been refused, a probability of 97.0099 percent—a numerical rhyme, whether designed or not, with the ninety-seven nightmares Reich's analyst counted in the first chapter (DM chs. 1, 13, pp. 15, 173); then the code department establishes that D'Courtney's reply to Reich's merger proposal, the four letters WWHG, signified acceptance, not refusal. The profit motive collapses, and with it the case. The computer had demanded what Powell could not supply: a motive of passion. In the last chapter Powell concedes the point to the Commissioner: the only one who grasped the case was the Prosecution Computer, whose demand for a passion motive the detectives had dismissed as the machine acting kittenish; once the mass cathexis has produced that motive, Mose backs the prosecution and the trial takes an hour (DM ch. 17, p. 229). The machine's actuarial wisdom registers what its operators have missed, that a premeditated murder without passion is improbable to the point of unintelligibility, but it can neither name nor discover the passion it requires. Here the novel engages the oldest maxim of the common law of crime, *actus non facit reum nisi mens sit rea*—the act does not make one guilty unless the mind is guilty. Telepathy is the fantasy of direct access to the *mens rea*; Bester's plot demonstrates that the guilty mind is double. Reich's conscious intent, to destroy a commercial rival who has refused him, is false; his unconscious intent, to destroy the father who abandoned him, is true. The law has no category for an unconscious *mens rea*, and the novel's resolution will require that law become therapy—that the spirit, in the Pauline idiom, supersede the letter.

Two further juridical details complicate this supersession. Reich's attorney successfully blocks the telepathic examination of his client: even in diaphanocracy a juridical right to mental privacy survives, a telepathic analogue of the privilege against self-incrimination. The novel states the right as constitutional: a man may refuse Esper examination without prejudice to himself. Powell's response is to turn the right into a trap, proposing to Maria Beaumont's guests that if every innocent person consents to be read, the one who refuses must be the killer—the logic of "nothing to hide" in its first

science-fictional form. The trap fails only because every guest has something to hide, and the narration names it: bastardy, perjury, adultery (DM ch. 6, pp. 77–81). And when Augustus Tate, Reich's purchased Esper, attempts to confess, Powell refuses testimony that would violate the Esper Pledge against betraying a patient's confidences. The transparent society, in other words, preserves institutional islands of opacity—the attorney's privilege, the physician's confidence—which function as legally guaranteed faces. These islands are the first evidence for the law of the opaque remainder: even a society that can see everything must decide, juridically and ethically, what it will refrain from seeing.

Kafka's *Der Process* (1925) supplies the inverse image. Josef K. is pronounced guilty by a court that never names his crime, and he cannot discover it; Reich knows his crime and is ignorant only of its motive, and the court of punched cards knows that the motive he offers is not his own. Kafka's law knows a guilt that the subject cannot locate; Bester's law knows that the subject's account of his guilt is false and waits, mechanically, for the truth.

2.4 *WWHG: The Purloined Letter*

The four letters on which the plot turns constitute a parapraxis of extraordinary density. Reich sends a coded proposal of merger; the reply WWHG arrives; he reads it as refusal and resolves to kill. Freud's *Psychopathology of Everyday Life* (1901) devotes a chapter to misreadings, in which the reader's unconscious substitutes the word it wishes, or fears, for the word on the page. His later essay "Negation" (1925) refines the mechanism: a repressed content may enter consciousness on condition that it is negated. WWHG—acceptance—enters Reich's consciousness as refusal because acceptance is unbearable. The merger proposal, read psychoanalytically, is the son's unconscious petition for union with the father, the corporate fusion of two bodies standing in for the reunion of an abandoned child with the man who abandoned him. The father's acceptance would gratify the wish too directly, exposing its object; negation preserves the wish by inverting its answer, and the inverted answer licenses the violence that the wish's ambivalence demands.

The scene of the murder makes the negation flesh. The dying D'Courtney, barely able to whisper through a cancer of the throat that the police laboratory calls psychogenic (DM ch. 6, p. 83), receives his assassin with open arms and a tender salutation and insists that he had accepted the offer; Reich refuses to believe him, forces open the old man's mouth with the blade of his knife-pistol, and fires. The scene inverts the parable of the prodigal son, and the narration names the allusion outright, describing D'Courtney advancing with outstretched arms as though welcoming a prodigal son (DM ch. 5, p. 62). In Luke the father, seeing him "yet a great way off," "ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him" (Luke 15:20). Here the father opens his arms and the son

kills him. The paternal word of reconciliation—spoken by a mouth that disease has already nearly silenced—is precisely the word the son cannot hear, and the mouth that speaks it is the organ the son destroys. Reich's replies in the scene are a catalogue of the mechanisms this chapter names. He hears the embrace as seduction and asks whether the old man is trying to make love to him; he calls it a Judas kiss; he remembers that he begged for merger like a screaming woman, for which every fighting Reich would blacken his face; and when D'Courtney mouths the four letters, he answers with a triple negation—refusal, denial, rejection (DM ch. 5, pp. 63–64). The murder takes place in an old wedding suite, where Reich has promised himself to marry his rival to murder (p. 58). The mouth is the novel's privileged site of the face. The first rule taught to Esper children, chanted in the Guild kindergarten, is to eliminate the larynx (DM ch. 7, p. 93); the father's throat has fallen silent of its own accord, and his last cry for help reaches his daughter only telepathically (ch. 17, p. 236); Reich forces the father's jaws open to kill him, Powell later holds Reich's jaws shut to make him swallow brandy (ch. 14, p. 190), and at the bottom of the de-creation a hand is laid over Reich's mouth (ch. 16, p. 222). Telepathy's utopia begins by abolishing the voice, and its crime is committed through the mouth.

Jacques Lacan's seminar on Poe's "The Purloined Letter" (1956) concluded that a letter always arrives at its destination; Derrida's riposte, "Le facteur de la vérité" (1975), insisted that the structural possibility of non-arrival haunts every message. Bester's cipher adjudicates between them in an unexpected way. WWHG does arrive at its destination—not at Reich the businessman but at Reich the son, at the unconscious that was always its true addressee—yet it arrives inverted. Lacan himself supplied the formula, in the Rome discourse of 1953, that human communication is the process by which the sender receives his own message back from the receiver in an inverted form. Reich's proposal of union returns to him as rejection, which was, in the economy of his ambivalence, the message he had sent. The cipher is the novel's purloined letter in the most literal sense. The page of the Executive's Code Book that Reich consults in the first chapter, printed in the novel's text, defines WWHG as ACCEPT OFFER beneath his own eyes and the reader's (DM ch. 1, p. 17); when the reply arrives he does not open the book again but reads the letters as refusal at once, and turns merger into murder by a near-rhyme (p. 25). Hidden in plain sight and decoded by no one until the end, the cipher is readable at last not by cryptography but by analysis—as Powell finally puts it, Reich was subconsciously compelled to misunderstand the message (ch. 17, p. 230).

2.5 *The Slip, the Need for Punishment, and the Turn from Detection to Analysis*

Powell's certainty of Reich's guilt is confirmed not by telepathy, which the jingle obstructs, but by a slip of the tongue: Reich remarks that Barbara D'Courtney was naked

as she fled, a detail only the murderer could know. The betrayal is Reikian in the strict sense. The compulsion to confess speaks through the very defenses erected against confession, and Reich's subsequent conduct conforms to the second half of Reik's thesis, the unconscious need for punishment. The detonation bulbs that explode in the massage alcove of his liner stateroom, in his safe, in his Jumper, and finally in his office desk were planted by Reich himself, in sleep and in brief daytime fugues (DM chs. 14, 16, 17); the Man With No Face, Powell explains, is his own guilt, and it has been trying to kill him.

Freud had anticipated the structure in "Criminals from a Sense of Guilt" (1916), where he reported patients whose misdeeds were committed because they were forbidden and whose sense of guilt preceded rather than followed the deed, so that the crime served to attach an unlocated guilt to something real. The chronology of *The Demolished Man* conforms exactly: the nightmares of the Man With No Face precede the murder, and the murder is undertaken explicitly to end them. In *The Ego and the Id* (1923) Freud described the superego of melancholia as a pure culture of the death drive, capable of driving the ego to its own destruction. Reich's somnambulistic sabotage is that culture made operational. The compulsion to confess completes itself at the end. Stripped of his universe by the mass cathexis, Reich asks a police station to let him confess the murder to Powell, and must spell his father's name letter by letter to an officer for whom neither the name, nor the killing, nor Powell exists (DM ch. 16, pp. 222–223). The confession Reik predicted arrives, and finds no law to receive it.

The epistemological consequence is the chapter's conclusion and the hinge of the novel. In a society that reads conscious intention, the only motive that can escape detection is one the criminal cannot read himself. Detection must therefore become analysis, the reading of what the subject does not know he knows; and law, which requires a motive the subject can avow, must yield to therapy, which seeks the motive the subject disavows. Old Man Mose, the letter that kills, demands the passion it cannot find; Powell, the spirit that gives life, must find it by entering the place where passion hides. That place, as the next chapter shows, is the family.

CHAPTER

3

The Fourth Parricide

Oedipus, Hamlet, Karamazov, Reich

The Demolished Man takes its place as the fourth term in the canon of parricide that Freud assembled from Sophocles, Shakespeare, and Dostoevsky, and it introduces two innovations into that canon: it displaces the parricidal motive onto capitalist rivalry, and it answers the parricide not with execution but with a collective, therapeutic unmaking of the son that inverts the primal murder of *Totem and Taboo*. This chapter names that inversion the second parricide.

3.1 *Freud's Canon and Its Fourth Term*

In "Dostoevsky and Parricide" (1928) Freud observed that three masterpieces of world literature—*Oedipus Tyrannus*, *Hamlet*, and *The Brothers Karamazov*—take parricide as their subject, and that each exposes, with differing degrees of disguise, a sexual rivalry for a woman as the motive. The three works may be ranked by the mechanism through which they displace the deed. Sophocles attributes it to fate and the hero's ignorance, and fuses detective and criminal in a single person whose investigation uncovers himself; Aristotle singled out the *Oedipus* for the coincidence of recognition and reversal, *anagnōrisis* and *peripeteia*, in a single moment (*Poetics* 1452a). Shakespeare displaces the deed onto an uncle who has already committed what the son unconsciously desired, so that the drama becomes one of inhibition—the reading Ernest Jones consolidated in *Hamlet and Oedipus* (1949), published while Bester was beginning his return to science fiction. Dostoevsky displaces the deed onto an illegitimate half-brother, Smerdyakov, who kills Fyodor Karamazov under the license of Ivan's dictum that, if God does not

exist, everything is permitted; the moral authorship belongs to the legitimate son, whose guilt returns to him as a hallucinated double, the devil of his nightmare.

Bester's novel combines and transforms these mechanisms. Reich is, like Smerdyakov, an unacknowledged bastard; like Oedipus, he does not know that his victim is his father; like Ivan, he is visited by a nocturnal double who embodies the guilt he cannot avow. But the displacement is new. The manifest motive is neither fate nor inhibition nor fraternal proxy but commercial rivalry: the son's desire to destroy the father appears to consciousness as the entrepreneur's desire to destroy a competitor. Capital supplies the manifest content of the parricidal dream. And Bester performs a second structural innovation: he splits the Sophoclean fusion of detective and criminal into two persons, Powell and Reich, only to fuse them again at the climax, when Powell's consciousness, carrying the concentrated energy of the Guild, enters Reich's and conducts him to the face he cannot see. The recognition that Sophocles assigns to a single mind Bester distributes between two and then rejoins.

The most consequential transformation concerns the woman. In Freud's canon the rivalry is for a woman—Jocasta, Gertrude, Grushenka. In Bester's novel she is almost wholly absent. Reich's mother appears only in the backstory of an affair and an abandonment; the only woman between father and son is the daughter Reich never knew existed. The object of desire is not the mother but the father himself, and the merger proposal—the son's petition for union—is legible as an expression of what psychoanalysis calls the negative Oedipus complex, which Freud, in 1923, described as the boy's affectionate, "feminine" attitude toward his father, with a corresponding jealousy and hostility toward his mother: a libidinal attachment to the father, not merely a filial one. *The Demolished Man* is, in this sense, the first great parricide narrative in which the parricidal hatred is the obverse of a frustrated love for the father, and the father's open arms at the moment of the murder are the unbearable proof that the love might have been returned.

3.2 *Laius, Abandonment, and the Family Romance*

The Oedipal parallel is more exact than the novel's commentators have noticed. In the myth, Laius, warned by the oracle, exposes the infant Oedipus on Cithaeron; the abandoned son survives, returns unknowing, and kills his father at a crossroads in a quarrel over precedence. D'Courtney, having fathered Reich in an affair, abandons him; the abandoned son survives, prospers, returns unknowing, and kills his father in a quarrel over market precedence. In 1953, the year of the novel's book publication, George Devereux argued in "Why Oedipus Killed Laius" that the son's hostility answers a prior hostility in the father—a "Laius complex" in which the parent's own aggression and abandonment generate the child's. Bester's novel insists on this complementarity. D'Courtney, the investigation discovers, appeared to welcome death; his physician con-

firms that he was suicidal but would never have taken his own life. The murder is the meeting point of two drives: the son's rage at abandonment and the father's guilty wish to die. Reich executes a sentence the father had already pronounced upon himself. The novel's diagnosis is technically Freudian: D'Courtney's physician reports that his Life and Death Instincts have defused, the two drives that, in the gloss Tate gives Reich, both seek Nirvana by opposite routes (DM ch. 4, pp. 40–41); his throat cancer is psychogenic; and his guilt, the physician later explains, concerns an abandoned child, though the detective at first assumes the child is Barbara (ch. 10, p. 132).

Freud's essay "Family Romances" (1909) described the child's fantasy that his true parents are of higher rank than those who raise him—that he is a foundling of royal or noble blood. Otto Rank's *Myth of the Birth of the Hero* (1909), published the same year, traced the narrative form of that fantasy across Sargon, Moses, Oedipus, Romulus, and others: the hero born of exalted parents, exposed in infancy, rescued and raised in humble circumstances, who returns to take vengeance on his father and assume his rank. Reich lives the family romance literally and as a curse. His true father is a king of commerce, but he has been raised as the heir of another dynasty: Monarch has belonged to the Reich family for generations, and his ancestors have even bequeathed him a book of counsel whose chapter on murder supplies the stratagem of the darkened party game. Rank's pattern is thus fulfilled in its culminating episode, the vengeance on the father, and inverted in its premise. Rank's hero is raised in humble circumstances and rises to the rank that is his by blood; Reich is raised in one royal house and destroys the other without knowing that it is his own. The foster dynasty bequeaths the technique; the blood dynasty supplies the victim. The technique arrives, moreover, as a written letter of inheritance from Geoffry Reich, founder of the clan, which praises "the killer instinct"—an instinct Reich at once claims as his blood (DM ch. 1, pp. 24–25). The last chapter discloses that the estate on Callisto Reich inherited from his mother had been D'Courtney's love-gift to her, and that Reich was born there (ch. 17, p. 230). His real patrimony was a gift of love; his claimed patrimony was a manual of murder. And the prosecution computer that judges him bears the name of the exposed foundling who became the lawgiver. Moses, the exemplary hero of Rank's study and the protagonist of Freud's last book, presides in mechanized form over the trial of a foundling who never discovered his name.

3.3 *Totem, Moses, and the Latency of Murder*

In *Totem and Taboo* (1913) Freud proposed that human society originated in a primal crime: the sons of the primal horde, excluded by a despotic father from the women of the group, banded together, killed and devoured him, and then, overcome by remorse, instituted in "deferred obedience" the two prohibitions the father had enforced in life —against killing the totem and against incest within the clan. Law, morality, and reli-

gion are, on this account, the dead father's will internalized by a fraternity bound together by shared guilt. *Moses and Monotheism* (1939) extended the hypothesis by adopting Ernst Sellin's conjecture that the Israelites had murdered Moses, and proposed that the murder, repressed, underwent a period of latency before returning in the form of a heightened religious fidelity, on the model of the individual neurosis: early trauma, defense, latency, outbreak, partial return of the repressed.

Bester's society may be read through this model with unusual precision. The Esper Guild is a fraternity in the strict sense, a sworn brotherhood bound by a Pledge; its seventy-nine years without a successful premeditated murder constitute a latency period, in which the prohibition of killing has been so thoroughly internalized and so effectively policed that its violent origin has vanished from view. Reich's crime is the return of the repressed in the social body: the first murder in eight decades is a parricide, as if the society's founding violence had returned in its original form. And the law that cannot comprehend this return—the computer that demands a passion it cannot name—is named for the murdered father of the Mosaic covenant, the lawgiver whose own assassination, on Freud's account, lies at the origin of the law he gave. The law cannot see parricide because it is parricide's residue.

3.4 *The Second Parricide*

The novel's response to the return of the repressed is its most remarkable invention. When legal proof has failed, the Guild Council authorizes the Mass Cathexis Measure, which concentrates the psychic energy of every Esper through a single human channel; Powell volunteers, although the procedure has a history of killing those who serve as its conduit. He justifies the measure by diagnosing Reich as a megalomaniac in embryo who, unchecked, would remake society in his own image; the delusion he then constructs—that Reich alone is real—is that megalomania taken at its word and then dismantled. Through this channel he constructs in Reich's mind an artificial delusion—the conviction that Reich alone is real in a fabricated universe—and then dismantles it layer by layer: the stars vanish, the planets disappear, the city crumbles, until Reich stands in absolute emptiness before the Man With No Face and sees there his own face merged with D'Courtney's. Powell and Reich are found the next morning in gardens overlooking the old Haarlem Canal, the detective near death and still gripping the murderer, who lies curled in a foetal ball (DM ch. 17, p. 228). The Council's minutes describe the request as one for Powell to serve as "the human canal" for the Guild's "Capitalized energy" (ch. 15, p. 198), and Powell later explains the operation to the Commissioner in the vocabulary of a balance sheet: every psyche holds latent energy, its untapped natural resources, and capitalized energy, the portion called up and put to work (ch. 17, p. 232). The commons defeats the capitalist by capitalizing itself.

Three theoretical frames converge on this scene. Freud's *Group Psychology and the Analysis of the Ego* (1921) defined a primary group as a number of individuals who have put one and the same object in the place of their ego ideal and have consequently identified with one another; the mass cathexis literalizes the formula, as the entire Guild cathects a single member and acts through him. Émile Durkheim's *Elementary Forms of the Religious Life* (1912) described the collective effervescence through which a society regenerates its sense of itself in rites of assembly; the mass cathexis is such a rite, the only moment in the novel in which the Guild acts as a single body. And René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) argued that communities resolve mimetic crises through unanimous violence against a single victim, the scapegoat whose expulsion restores order; the mass cathexis is unanimous psychic violence against one man, a ritual of all against one sublimated into therapy.

The structure that results inverts *Totem and Taboo*. In Freud's myth, the band of brothers kills the father and becomes, through guilt, the bearer of his law. In Bester's novel, a son has killed the father, and the band of brothers responds not by killing the son but by unmaking him: by destroying his world, confronting him with his identification with the father, reducing him to the fetal posture from which he will be rebuilt. The fraternity thereby occupies the father's vacant place—as judge, as guardian, as the parent of the person who will emerge from Demolition. I call this the second parricide because its object is the paternal function itself, which passes from the murdered patriarch to the collective that unmakes his murderer; and because, in another sense, the son who is unmade had become, by his crime, the bearer of the father's sovereign violence. The scene's imagery confirms the theological resonance: the dismantling of the cosmos reverses the order of Genesis, the garden in which the antagonists are found recalls both Eden and Gethsemane, and the channel who risks death so that another may be reborn performs a recognizably Christic office.

The second parricide completes a transfer of dynastic custody. D'Courtney had two children. His daughter, regressed by trauma and by the Déjà Éprouvé Series, is raised again in Powell's house and becomes his bride. His son, unmade by the mass cathexis and erased by Demolition, will be raised again in the hospital under the Guild's supervision. Both children of the capitalist patriarch end in the custody of the telepathic commons, which has become, in the most literal sense, their parent. The novel draws this structure inside Barbara's unconscious. Descending into her id, Powell follows the chain of associations from Papa to Father and finds himself face to face with his own image, haloed, its arms outstretched; at the back of that head is D'Courtney's face—a Janus figure whose front belongs to the new father and whose rear, exactly where the bullet left the old man's skull, belongs to the old—and below it Barbara and Reich are joined like Siamese twins, half joined in blood (DM ch. 11, pp. 149–150). The later reception of Bester's world made this latent structure manifest. The Psi Corps of J.

Michael Straczynski's television series *Babylon 5* (1994–1998), an explicit homage whose most sinister officer bears the name Alfred Bester, proclaims in its official motto: "The Corps is mother, the Corps is father." What Bester's novel stages as a benign succession, its descendant recognized as the founding claim of a totalitarian institution.

Roberto Esposito's account of the immunitary paradigm (*Immunitas*, 2002) offers a final gloss. Communities protect themselves, Esposito argues, by incorporating the negative in attenuated form, as a body is immunized by a controlled dose of the pathogen. Demolition is immunization in this sense: the commons absorbs the parricide's energy rather than expelling it, converting the force that threatened it into a resource for its own preservation.

3.5 *The Sister, the Daughter, the Bride*

The novel's second plot, the regression and courtship of Barbara D'Courtney, mirrors the first with a symmetry that is as revealing as it is troubling. Barbara witnesses her father's murder, seizes the weapon, and flees; found catatonic, she reenacts the entire scene whenever she hears the word "help"—a textbook instance of the repetition compulsion Freud theorized in *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920). Treated by the Déjà Éprouvé Series, she regresses to infancy and grows up again in Powell's house, regarding him first as a father and then as a lover. Where Reich is the bad son who kills the father, Powell is the good father who marries the daughter. The two romances are Oedipal mirror images, and the Pygmalion myth—Ovid's sculptor who falls in love with the woman he has made, Shaw's phonetician who remakes a flower girl—names the second with uncomfortable exactness. Bester supplies the doll himself: dressed and combed for her first session, the catatonic Barbara is described as a lovely wax-work doll, lovely outside and mangled inside (DM ch. 10, p. 124)—the Olympia of Hoffmann's tale, loved because she is a mechanism.

A feminist critique of this structure is indispensable, and it confirms rather than distracts from the thesis of this dissertation. The transparency of Bester's world is gendered. Men read; women are read, regressed, and rebuilt. Mary Noyes, the Second Class Esper who loves Powell without return, serves as nurse and surrogate mother to the woman who will replace her, and is paralyzed by Reich in the course of her service. Barbara's personhood is literally reconstructed under the masculine gaze of the therapeutic institution. The asymmetry should be stated plainly. Powell's love forms while he is reading the mind of a woman whom trauma and treatment have regressed to infancy and placed in his custody; she can consent neither to the treatment nor to the attachment it fosters, and the novel postpones the declaration of love until her recovery without examining where it began. The text supplies the particulars. In her infant phase Powell coaxes her to call him Dada; in her child phase she announces that she will marry Papa when she grows up and that she is growing up because he promised

to wait for her, and Powell answers that it is a promise; when Reich invades the house, Powell has deliberately triggered her traumatic recall in front of him as, in his own word, an experiment (DM chs. 10, 14, pp. 136, 186–188). Mary Noyes puts the question the novel cannot answer when she asks which part of this half-made woman Powell loves: one tenth of her, her subconscious, or her face (ch. 11, p. 151). Joanna Russ's critique of the figure of woman in mid-century science fiction (1972) applies with full force. Most revealing is the mechanism by which the romance is finally licensed. Barbara recalls being awakened on the night of the murder by a cry of "Help, Barbara"—a cry her father, whose cancer had silenced his voice, could only have sent telepathically. She is therefore a latent Esper, and the Guild, which governs its members' marriages in the service of its eugenic program, will not forbid the union. Love in diaphanocracy must be retroactively certified as transparency. Until that discovery, Powell tells Mary that the Guild will not let its members marry normals and that he could offer Barbara nothing more than an affair; and the proposal, when it comes, is itself a telepathic test, for Powell proves her latency by asking whether she loves him without saying the words aloud, and she answers (DM chs. 15, 17, pp. 203, 236–237). The one relationship in the novel that might have crossed the boundary between the seeing and the seen is redescribed, at the last moment, as a relationship within it.

The sibling bond, finally, bears an index of the incest taboo that survives the collapse of the prohibition against murder. Reich, who kills his father and stands ready to silence anyone who might expose him, cannot bring himself to harm the half-sister whose identity he does not know; and the child Barbara, at the climax of his invasion of Powell's house, innocently takes his hand. Of the two taboos Freud derived from the primal murder, one fails and the other holds. Plato had already joined invisibility, regicide, and possession of the royal woman in the fable of Gyges, the shepherd whose ring of invisibility enabled him to seduce the queen, kill the king, and seize the throne (*Republic* 359c–360d). Reich possesses a ring of mental invisibility in his jingle and kills his king, but the royal woman passes to his adversary. The Gyges plot, too, has been divided between antagonists—an anticipation of the next chapter's argument that the jingle is the ring of Gyges turned inward.

CHAPTER

4

Diaphanocracy

The Political Theology and Political Economy of the Telepathic Commons

The Esper Guild is not merely a police instrument but a polity, and its distinctive form—a credentialed fraternity of mind-readers, governed by a pledge of discretion, pursuing through eugenic marriage the eventual telepathic transformation of the species—constitutes a political type for which the existing vocabulary of surveillance is inadequate. This chapter names that type diaphanocracy and analyzes it along two axes: as political theology, the secular successor of the pastorate and the ecclesia; and as political economy, the antagonist of a capitalism founded on private information.

4.1 *The Guild as Polity*

The three classes of Espers function as estates, distinguished not by birth or property but by depth of access: the Third Class reads the surface of consciousness, the Second the preconscious, the First the unconscious. The Guild's Pledge, engraved on a gold plaque at the Guild Institute as a close adaptation of the Hippocratic Oath (DM ch. 7, pp. 93–94), binds its members to discretion toward those they read, and the novel takes its provisions seriously enough to let them obstruct the investigation, as when Powell refuses the testimony of the conscience-stricken Tate because it would betray a patient's confidence. The adaptation is pointed. Where the physician swore to give no deadly drug, the Esper swears to give no deadly thought; where the physician kept silent about what he saw and heard in the houses he entered, the Esper keeps silent about what he finds in the minds he enters; and the first clause, retained from the an-

cient oath, binds the initiate to regard his teacher as one of his parents and the teacher's children as his own brethren. The Guild is constituted as a family by oath before it ever claims custody of anyone. Georg Simmel's essay on "The Secret and the Secret Society" (1908), translated into English in 1950 in *The Sociology of Georg Simmel*, defined discretion as the restraint by which one refrains from knowing what another does not expressly reveal, and argued that social life depends as much upon reciprocal ignorance as upon reciprocal knowledge. The Pledge is Simmelian discretion codified as the constitution of a polity. Diaphanocracy is not the abolition of secrecy but its relocation from the subject, who can no longer keep secrets, to the institution, which promises to keep them on the subject's behalf. The readers reserve opacity for themselves. Upper-grade Espers live in private stone houses because thought cannot pass through masonry and a flimsy apartment would be, for a telepath, an inferno of naked emotion; Powell, like most of his class, requires large quantities of solitude (DM ch. 3, p. 31). The commons is transparent for normals and walled for its elite.

The Guild's gravest sanction confirms the inversion. Jerry Church, a former Second Class Esper, was expelled—by Powell himself—for his part in the Chaos Swindle, in which he peeped four members of the Stock Exchange for Reich (DM ch. 11, p. 141), and his condition—cut off from the telepathic communion of his peers, condemned to the solitude of his own opacity—is presented as a fate worse than imprisonment; in one of the novel's most desolate images, he stands outside Powell's house during an Esper party, eavesdropping on a communion from which he has been cut off. The narration calls his exile the bend sinister of ostracism, borrowing the heraldic mark of bastardy, and Powell's offer of a drink breaks what Powell himself calls a taboo (DM ch. 3, pp. 37–39): in the commons, exclusion is figured as illegitimacy, and contact with the excluded is forbidden as the totemic order forbids it. In a society founded on transparency, opacity becomes the penalty; excommunication, in its etymological sense, is the deprivation of communion. Augustus Tate's corruption marks the opposite danger. Reich purchases Tate with the promise of the presidency of a restructured Guild, and the bargain exposes the temptation latent in every professional caste: to convert a monopoly of insight into a monopoly of rule. Capital's attempt to capture the commons proceeds, as it always has, through the ambitions of the commons' own officers. Tate belongs, moreover, to the League of Esper Patriots, the Guild's ultra-reactionary faction, and resents the steep levy the Guild imposes on its members' earnings to fund its education, outreach, and eugenic programs: the commons is a redistributive polity, and its reactionaries are its tax resisters. The commons is present in the state as well: the vacationing Espers Powell conscripts as a living radar at Spaceland include a judge, a Secretary of Political Psychology, two Cabinet members, and five Parliamentary Leaders (DM ch. 12, p. 160).

4.2 *Universalism, Eugenics, and Hope*

The Guild's ultimate aim is universal: a future in which all humanity will be joined, as Powell prophesies in the novel's final lines, in a communion of minds and hearts. Its means are particularist: the Guild supervises its members' marriages so as to propagate the telepathic gift, pressing Powell to marry within the Esper population as a condition of his eligibility for the Guild's presidency. The novel registers an internal dissent as well: D'Courtney's physician, Sam @kins, leads the Environment Clique, which holds telepathy to be not a congenital characteristic but a latent quality of every living organism, capable of being drawn out by training (DM ch. 10, p. 128). The hereditarian and the educational roads to universal telepathy are the Guild's version of the controversy between nature and nurture, and the novel's revelations of latency—in Chooka Frood's fortune-telling act, in Barbara D'Courtney's telepathic hearing of her father's last cry—tilt the balance quietly toward the second. The tension reproduces the structure Alain Badiou analyzed in *Saint Paul: The Foundation of Universalism* (1997), in which a universal truth addressed to all must nonetheless be borne by a particular community of the faithful; the Pauline proclamation that "there is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither bond nor free, there is neither male nor female" (Galatians 3:28) is the charter of every universalism that must be carried by a remnant. In the Guild, however, the remnant reproduces itself biologically, and its universalism is shadowed by eugenics—the hereditarian movement that, within living memory of the novel, had produced compulsory-sterilization statutes in more than thirty American states—upheld by the Supreme Court in 1927 in an opinion in which Justice Oliver Wendell Holmes Jr. wrote that "three generations of imbeciles are enough"—as well as Nazi Germany's sterilization law of 1933, under which some 400,000 people were sterilized, and the regime's murder of disabled people in the T4 program and its successors, which killed some 70,000 by August 1941 and, by most estimates, more than 200,000 in all. The Guild's program differs in kind—it is marital and voluntary, and it seeks to spread a gift rather than to eliminate those judged unfit—but it inherits the hereditarian premise, which science fiction elaborated both before and after Bester, in Robert A. Heinlein's Howard Families (1941) and Frank Herbert's Bene Gesserit (1965). A further allegorical layer may be read, with appropriate caution, through Bester's own position as a writer of Jewish descent in postwar New York: a community of professional interpreters of minds, practicing an art that National Socialist propaganda had denounced as a "Jewish science," encouraged toward endogamy while proclaiming a mission to all humanity, enacts the characteristic dilemma of an assimilated minority suspended between particularity and universality. The denunciation had consequences: Freud's books were among those burned in Berlin on 10 May 1933; after the annexation of Austria in 1938 the regime broke up Vienna's psychoanalytic institutions and drove Freud into exile in London, where he died the following year; and four of

his sisters, deported in 1942, died in Nazi camps. The novel itself makes the allegory difficult to dismiss. The smear campaign Reich finances against the Espers accuses them of being clannish, untrustworthy, never patriots, interplanetary conspirators who eat Normal babies (DM ch. 10, p. 124)—the canards of antisemitic propaganda, blood libel included—and Powell warns the Guild Council that unless it is stopped the Espers may suffer the usual history of minority groups (ch. 15, p. 198). The Guild's president, T'sung H'sai, drawn in the stereotyped idiom of 1952 as a portly mandarin, denounces the League of Esper Patriots for its talk of purity of the race and aristocracy and calls its campaign against the Guild's education levy fascism (ch. 7, pp. 94–95). The Guild's eugenics, in other words, defines itself against racial purity: it aims to spread the gift, not to hoard it.

The Guild's very name carries a felicitous homophony. *Esper*, a back-formation from ESP, chimes with the Latin *spes* and the Spanish *esperanza*, and with *Esperanto*, the universal language Zamenhof published in 1887 under a pseudonym meaning "one who hopes." Telepathy is the Esperanto of minds. Ernst Bloch, whose *Das Prinzip Hoffnung* began to appear in 1954, distinguished Freud's unconscious, a *no-longer-conscious* sedimented from the repressed past, from what he called the *not-yet-conscious*, the anticipatory preconscious in which the new announces itself before it can be named. *The Demolished Man* stages the conflict of these two unconsciouses. Reich's is Freudian, turned backward toward the abandoning father; the Guild's telepathic program is Blochian, turned forward toward a species that does not yet exist. The novel's plot is the victory of the second over the first, and its unresolved question is whether that victory requires the annihilation of the past it overcomes.

4.3 *The Metaphysics of the Commons*

Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* announces the arrival of Spirit as the experience of an "'I' that is 'We' and 'We' that is 'I'" (§177); Durkheim's *conscience collective* names the body of beliefs and sentiments common to a society's members; Freud's speculative phylogeny of thought-transference located a direct psychical communion at humanity's archaic origin. Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937) had already imagined telepathic group minds as the destiny of evolved intelligence. Bester's Guild belongs to this lineage, but it rests on a more specific philosophical premise, which Nietzsche formulated in *Beyond Good and Evil* (1886, §17): a thought comes when "it" wills, not when "I" will. If thought is not the property of an ego but an event that occurs in it, then thought can be shared, intercepted, and read; the telepathic commons presupposes the impersonality of thinking. The novel states its own metaphysics in a sentence about Mary Noyes, who is dark and short to the eye but frost-white in mental pattern: the mind is the reality, the narrator declares, and one is

what one thinks (DM ch. 3, p. 32). It is the post-facial doctrine in its simplest form—the exterior is appearance, the pattern is the person.

The political consequence is the reversal of a founding axiom of liberalism. Locke's *Second Treatise* (1689, §27) grounded property in the proposition that "every Man has a Property in his own Person," to which nobody has any right but himself. The mind is the last and most intimate of these properties, and telepathy expropriates it. Diaphanocracy is the reversal of enclosure: where the early modern enclosures converted common land into private property, the telepathic commons converts the most private of properties—the content of consciousness—into a common resource, held in trust by a professional estate. Reich, the proprietor, defends the last enclosure; the Guild, the commons, dissolves it.

4.4 *From Sovereignty to Pastoral Power*

Michel Foucault distinguished the sovereign power that "takes life or lets live" from the biopower that "makes live and lets die," and traced, in *Discipline and Punish* (1975), the passage from punishment inscribed on the body to correction addressed to the soul. *The Demolished Man* allegorizes this passage with schematic clarity. Reich, master of Monarch, is a private sovereign who arrogates the right of death; his murder is the sovereign act par excellence, performed by capital in a society that has abolished capital punishment. Foucault located the modern extreme of this sovereign right in the Nazi state, which, in his Collège de France lecture of 17 March 1976, he described as having generalized biopower absolutely while generalizing at the same time the sovereign right to kill; a novel written seven years after that state's destruction gives its private sovereign the name Reich. The Guild answers with a power that refuses to kill and undertakes instead to remake life. In his 1979 Tanner Lectures, "Omnes et Singulatim," Foucault traced modern governmentality to the Christian pastorate, whose shepherd must know the conscience of each member of the flock individually and of all together. Telepathy is the perfection of pastoral power: a shepherd who need not wait for confession because he reads the conscience directly, all and each.

Bentham's *Panopticon* (1791) produced discipline through the possibility of being seen; Bester's Espers produce it through the certainty of being read. Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) characterized the police of modern states as a power that is *gestaltlos*—formless, nowhere tangible, all-pervasive, spectral—because it combines the law-making and law-preserving functions that the constitutional order is supposed to separate. The Esper police is Benjamin's spectral police perfected, a power that inhabits every mind it might need to examine. Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (1924), with its glass apartments and its citizens' pride in having nothing to hide, had already imagined transparency as a utopian ideal under a single Benefactor. Byung-Chul Han's *The Transparency Society* (2012) diagnoses its contemporary form as a regime of positivity

that abolishes negativity, distance, and the Other, and that renders trust unnecessary because trust is possible only between knowing and not-knowing. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974) showed how, on the anarchist world of Anarres, social conscience could exercise a coercion without telepathy that rivals any police. Bester stages the fashion of exposure directly. At Maria Beaumont's party the guests wear ultraviolet windows in their clothes that dissolve under the changing lights, and Reich alone stands in an opaque suit, contemptuous of the roving eyes; when the game ends, the hostess floods her stage with light to catch her guests naked, and complains that Reich, still dressed, has cheated (DM ch. 5, pp. 54, 68).

What distinguishes Bester's diaphanocracy from all of these is its asymmetry. Espers read normals; normals cannot read Espers. The relation is structurally identical to the one Shoshana Zuboff has described as surveillance capitalism, in which users are rendered transparent to an apparatus she calls "Big Other" while the apparatus remains opaque to them (Zuboff 2015, 2019). Bester's novel imagines this asymmetry as benevolent, sanctified by a Pledge and directed toward the eventual elevation of the read into readers. Its contemporary realization has retained the asymmetry and dispensed with the Pledge. Capital in the novel already practices a version of its own. Reich keeps a dossier of prominent people under headings such as BRIBERY (POTENTIAL) (DM ch. 1, p. 24); his household is staffed by telepaths who serve his unspoken wishes; Monarch maintains a private police, for whom its physiologist developed the blinding weapon, originally intended for strike riots (chs. 2, 13, pp. 29–30, 170); and when Reich needs to find Barbara he founds a charity, Sanctuary, whose every applicant's photograph and description is relayed to him, alongside an advertising contest for a Jumper Girl whose specifications are Barbara's face and body (ch. 8, pp. 101–102). Surveillance by charity and by advertisement is the capitalist's own diaphanocracy.

4.5 *The Political Economy of Opacity*

Friedrich Hayek's "The Use of Knowledge in Society" (1945) argued that the economic problem of society is the coordination of knowledge dispersed among millions of individuals, much of it tacit and local, which no central planner could ever collect, and that the price system is the mechanism through which this unassembled knowledge is brought to bear. The argument was the culmination of the socialist calculation debate inaugurated by Ludwig von Mises in 1920 and answered by Oskar Lange in 1936–1937. Telepathy is the fantasy of dissolving Hayek's problem at its root. If every mind can be read, dispersed knowledge becomes collectible, and the epistemic warrant for markets —that no one can know what everyone knows—disappears. The Guild's universal telepathy would be, among other things, the solution to the calculation problem. The novel complicates the fantasy in a revealing way. Guild Law forbids peepers to speculate or gamble (DM ch. 7, p. 92), so that the commons deliberately keeps telepathy out

of the market; the one time the novel shows telepathy entering it, in the Chaos Swindle, it does so as insider trading for Reich's profit and costs Church his membership (ch. 11, p. 141). When the Guild finally moves against Reich, it does so by withdrawing telepathic labor from private capital, ruling Monarch's espionage unethical and ending exclusive private retainers in the name of the most good for the most people (ch. 14, p. 178). Diaphanocracy preserves the opacity of the market by law and reserves transparency for the commons.

Reich's capitalism, by contrast, is a capitalism of secrecy. It runs on ciphers, code departments, sealed communications, and private information, and its decisive document is a coded telegram. Reich says so himself: no one runs Monarch without building a stock-pile of secrets that have to be protected (DM ch. 6, p. 76). Even Monarch's books are opaque to Monarch, which employs a full-time telepathic accountant to trace the labyrinth of its own subsidiaries (ch. 1, p. 16). The novel's deepest economic insight is that the misreading of that telegram is not a failure of communication between rivals but a failure of self-knowledge: the private information that matters most is opaque even to its owner. Michael Polanyi would later formulate the principle that "we can know more than we can tell" (*The Tacit Dimension*, 1966); Reich knows more than he can tell himself. The opacity of the market, Bester's plot implies, is grounded in the opacity of the subject to itself. Capitalism is the economic form of the unconscious.

The novel's antagonism is therefore a contest between two monopolies. The cartel monopolizes capital; the Guild, like its medieval namesakes, monopolizes a craft—here the craft of reading minds. Tate's corruption is the attempt of the first monopoly to purchase the second. Frederik Pohl and C. M. Kornbluth's contemporaneous *The Space Merchants* imagined the corporation as sovereign; Isaac Asimov's Foundation series, whose concluding volume appeared in 1953, imagined a hidden fraternity of mentalics, the Second Foundation, guarding the statistical science of mass psychology against the one variable it cannot predict, the mutant individual called the Mule. The Mule is the opaque remainder of psychohistory, as Reich's unconscious is the opaque remainder of telepathy: in both, a transparent order is threatened not by a rival order but by a singular will that no statistics and no Esper can read in advance.

4.6 *Commodity Armor: The Jingle and the Ring of Gyges*

Reich's defense against the transparent society is a commercial jingle. He tricks the songwriter Duffy Wyg&, who has done advertising work for Monarch, into playing him a tune of exceptional persistence, "Tenser, Said the Tensor," which lodges in his mind as a shield against telepathic probing: the surface of consciousness is occupied so completely by mechanical repetition that intention cannot be read beneath it. Its provenance is exact. Duffy Wyg& runs Psych-Songs, Inc.; she has written sales jingles for Monarch and strike-breaking songs for its propaganda department during the previ-

ous year's labor dispute; the tune was composed for a failed show about a mad mathematician and withdrawn because audiences could not shake it; its trick, she explains, is a semicadence after the last word, so that the song can never end; and the trade calls such tunes Pepsis, after a soft-drink jingle of the distant past (DM ch. 4, pp. 44–46). The industry that composes conditioning for strikers supplies the murderer's privacy. Theodor W. Adorno's essay "On the Fetish-Character in Music and the Regression of Listening" (1938) and the chapter on the culture industry in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) analyzed the standardized hit as an instrument for colonizing consciousness, a commodity that occupies the mind by repetition and leaves no room for reflection. Bester inverts the critique with startling intelligence. The culture industry's colonization of consciousness becomes the last refuge of the private self: in diaphanocracy, the only enclosure left is the commodity. Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927, §35) described idle talk, *Gerede*, as the discourse that closes things off by appearing to say everything; the jingle is *Gerede* in its purest form, a speech that conceals by never ceasing. In Shannon's terms it is engineered noise; in Wilhelm Reich's, character armor installed by an act of will. Within a few years of the novel's publication, a Montreal psychiatrist would be playing recorded messages to patients for up to sixteen hours a day in order to install new contents in minds he had first set out to empty (Chapter Five): Reich's jingle, inverted, had become a clinical protocol. Bester himself draws the parallel between the jingle and trauma: Barbara's hysterical recall, the tenth chapter begins, is like a recording crystal so warped that it can reproduce only one terrifying phrase over and over (DM ch. 10, p. 122). Defense and symptom share a single form, the compulsion to repeat.

In the second book of the *Republic*, Glaucon challenges Socrates with the fable of Gyges, whose ring of invisibility licensed him to commit every injustice, and argues that justice is merely the fear of being seen. Bester's society is an anti-Gyges order: normals are always visible to Espers, and premeditated murder has vanished—an outcome that seems to vindicate Glaucon's cynicism. The jingle is the ring of Gyges turned inward, and the first man to wear it kills his king at once. The novel supplies the literal invisibility as well: when the lights go out on the naked game of Sardine, the narration reports that Reich is invisible at last (DM ch. 5, p. 59), and at Chooka Frood's he watches his enemies, unseen, through a voyeur's floor of transparent crystal (ch. 9, p. 119). But the novel's answer to Glaucon is subtler than his challenge. The ring fails not because the Guild sees through it but because its wearer cannot hide from himself. The slip of the tongue and the somnambulistic attempts on his own life betray him from within. Justice, on Bester's account, is not only the fear of being seen by others; it is also the unconscious demand to be seen, the compulsion to confess that Reik placed at the heart of the criminal psyche. H. G. Wells's *The Invisible Man* (1897), whose scientist discovers in invisibility a license for megalomania and crime, gave science fiction its first

modern Gyges. Bester's version internalizes invisibility and then shows that it cannot be internalized completely: the mind that hides from others is still visible to its own unconscious, which wants nothing so much as to be found.

CHAPTER

5

Demolition

The Therapeutic State, the Pauline New Man, and the Bloodless Sacrifice

Demolition, the penalty that gives the novel its title and that the narrative withholds until its final pages, is the most radical rehabilitative fantasy in twentieth-century fiction. This chapter argues that it is also a disguised execution: measured by the criterion of personal identity that modern jurisprudence inherited from Locke, the procedure kills the person it claims to cure, and the society that boasts of having abolished capital punishment has merely relocated it from the body to the persona.

5.1 *The Procedure and Its Withholding*

Throughout the novel Demolition functions as a sanction whose content is unknown: Reich fears it, the reader fears it, and its terror derives precisely from its namelessness. The penalty is, until the last chapter, a faceless threat, and its structural position in the narrative mirrors that of the Man With No Face in Reich's dreams. When at last it is described, it proves to be neither torture nor death in the ordinary sense but erasure: by means of injections that shut down every memory while consciousness is maintained, the criminal's personality is dissolved, and a new person is allowed to develop in the same body, under medical supervision, over the course of about a year. The logic of the procedure is conservation. The body survives, the capacities survive, and the energies that drove the crime are preserved for redirection; what is destroyed is the historical person, the accumulated self that remembered, desired, and killed. The novel's own description does not soften this. Its horror, the narrator explains, is that consciousness

is never lost: as the psyche is wiped out the mind is aware of its slow, backward death, bids an eternity of farewells, and mourns at an endless funeral (DM ch. 17, p. 237). Kingston Hospital, where the procedure is performed, is landscaped like a resort, and its governors must keep out fashionable malingerers lest it become another Spaceland (pp. 233–234); its physicians, one of them boasts, have begun to work on death itself (ch. 10, p. 122).

The narrative withholding is itself a thesis about punishment. A sanction known only by its name operates as pure deterrent, an object of anxiety rather than of calculation; when its content is revealed, its function changes from deterrence to therapy. The novel's structure thus recapitulates the historical passage Foucault traced from the spectacle of punishment to the correction of the soul, but in reverse order of disclosure: the reader experiences the old terror first and learns only at the end that the punishment has become a cure.

5.2 *The Philosophy of Punishment from Plato to Foucault*

Plato's *Gorgias* (476a–480d) argued that punishment benefits the wrongdoer as medicine benefits the sick, and that the unjust man should hasten to the judge as the patient to the physician; the *Laws* (IX, 862c–863a) elaborated a curative penology while reserving death for the incurable. Bester's society adopts the Platonic premise and abolishes the Platonic limit: it recognizes no incurables. Cesare Beccaria's *Dei delitti e delle pene* (1764) opposed the death penalty on utilitarian and contractarian grounds and demanded proportion between crime and punishment; Demolition satisfies the first demand and dissolves the second, since a procedure that remakes the whole person admits of no proportion. Jeremy Bentham's *Panopticon* (1791) promised an institution that would serve as "a mill for grinding rogues honest"; Demolition is the perfected mill, grinding not the conduct but the personality itself.

The retributivist tradition supplies the sharpest objections. Kant, in the *Metaphysics of Morals* (1797), insisted that punishment may never be inflicted merely as a means to promote some other good, and that even a civil society about to dissolve itself must first execute the last murderer in its prisons so that blood-guilt should not cling to the people. Demolition uses the criminal as a means par excellence, converting his energies into a social resource. Hegel, in the *Philosophy of Right* (1820, §100 Remark), argued that punishment honors the criminal as a rational being by treating his deed as his own law; to treat him instead as a harmful animal to be rendered harmless or a patient to be reformed denies him the dignity of having acted. Demolition denies Reich the right to his punishment. It refuses to recognize his crime as a free act and treats it as a symptom.

Nietzsche's *Genealogy of Morality* (1887) complicates both camps. The moral concept of guilt, *Schuld*, descends from the material concept of debt, *Schulden*, and punishment

originated in the creditor's right to extract compensation from the debtor's body (II, §§4–6); the meaning of punishment, moreover, is historically fluid, a palimpsest of purposes (II, §13). Reich, the creditor-capitalist, discovers that his guilt is an unpayable debt to a father he never knew, and Demolition settles the account not in blood but in the whole of his personality. Nietzsche also feared that the meaning of culture was the reduction of the human beast of prey to a tame and civilized animal (I, §11). Demolition is that reduction performed on a single exemplary predator. Finally, Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975), which characterized the modern soul as the prison of the body, describes the epoch whose limit Demolition marks: a punishment addressed exclusively to the soul, leaving the body untouched and the soul erased.

5.3 *The Therapeutic State, 1949–1968*

The novel's police division is itself named for psychosis—Powell is Prefect of the Psychotic Division, and the deputy who first reports the murder reasons that only a distorted mind can produce death by violence (DM ch. 6, p. 70)—and its penal utopia was conceived at the zenith of what Francis A. Allen, in 1959, called the rehabilitative ideal: the conviction that criminal sanctions should aim at the therapeutic transformation of the offender, administered through indeterminate sentences by experts in human behavior. The most penetrating contemporaneous critique of that ideal appeared in 1949, as Bester was approaching his novel. In "The Humanitarian Theory of Punishment," C. S. Lewis argued that to replace desert with cure is to remove the only principle that limits punishment: a sentence measured by what the offender deserves has an end, whereas a treatment measured by what experts judge necessary has none; and to be remade against one's will is to be classed with infants, imbeciles, and domestic animals. Lewis had dramatized the danger in *That Hideous Strength* (1945), whose sinister institute proposes the "remedial treatment" of offenders. Thomas Szasz would later name the political form these critiques anticipated the therapeutic state (*Law, Liberty, and Psychiatry*, 1963), and Karl Menninger would defend it in *The Crime of Punishment* (1968), arguing that punishment was itself a crime and that offenders should be treated rather than penalized.

The therapeutic state had material instruments. Egas Moniz received the Nobel Prize in 1949 for prefrontal leucotomy, the surgical severing of connections to the brain's frontal lobes. In the United States the neurologist Walter Freeman, at first with the neurosurgeon James Watts, performed or supervised several thousand lobotomies, from 1946 increasingly by a transorbital method he carried from one state hospital to another; tens of thousands of Americans had been lobotomized by the mid-1950s, many of them institutionalized patients in no position to give meaningful consent. The operation's characteristic result was a flattened, diminished personality in an intact body—Demolition's outcome without its promise of rebirth. Its most famous casualty

was Rosemary Kennedy, lobotomized by Freeman and Watts in 1941 at her father's request and left permanently incapacitated. The brainwashing panic supplied the nightmare version. Robert Jay Lifton's *Thought Reform and the Psychology of Totalism* (1961), based on interviews with subjects of Chinese re-education, described a sequence of assault upon identity, induced guilt, self-betrayal, a breaking point, leniency, compulsive confession, re-education, and rebirth; among the themes of totalism he identified the cult of confession and "the dispensing of existence," the group's claim to decide who has the right to exist. The mass cathexis and Demolition reproduce Lifton's sequence almost stage by stage: the assault on Reich's world, his confrontation with his guilt, the breaking point in absolute emptiness, the fetal collapse, the erasure, the rebirth. What Lifton described as totalism, Bester presents as cure. Bester's detective is franker than his narrator. The mass cathexis, he tells the Commissioner, was necessary because the police had to make Reich see the truth before they could get it; once Reich had looked into the face and seen himself and his father, "we had everything," and the trial that followed took an hour (DM ch. 17, pp. 229–233). The cure was also an interrogation.

The nightmare also had a Western clinic. Between 1957 and 1964, at the Allan Memorial Institute of McGill University in Montreal, the psychiatrist D. Ewen Cameron conducted the experiments later designated Subproject 68 of MKULTRA, the Central Intelligence Agency's program of research in behavioral modification. Cameron was no marginal figure. He had presided over the American Psychiatric Association in 1952–1953, an office the *American Journal of Psychiatry* marked with a biographical sketch of him by Gregory Zilboorg, the first translator of Zamyatin's *We*; in 1961 he became president of the World Psychiatric Association. His method had two stages. In the first, which he called depatterning, patients were held in drug-induced sleep for days or weeks, in some cases for nearly three months; given electroconvulsive shocks in several sessions a day, far beyond standard practice; and subjected to sensory deprivation and to drugs including LSD, until their existing patterns of memory and behavior had been broken down. In the second, which he called psychic driving, recorded messages were played to them for up to sixteen hours a day—first negative statements about themselves, then positive ones—repeated over a course of treatment as many as half a million times. The CIA paid for part of this work through a front organization, the Society for the Investigation of Human Ecology; the Canadian Department of National Health and Welfare funded more of it, including a study of personality change under the "prolonged repetition of verbal signals." Whether Cameron knew the American source of his money remains disputed.

His patients had come to him for treatment of conditions such as depression, and none had given informed consent—the principle the Nuremberg Code of 1947 placed first: "The voluntary consent of the human subject is absolutely essential." Many were left with retrograde amnesia for the rest of their lives; some were reduced to a childlike

condition and had to relearn the skills of ordinary life. A 1986 report commissioned by Canada's Department of Justice found the allegations of depatterning and psychic driving factual and the methods unsound, while clearing the funding department of irresponsibility. The CIA had destroyed its MKULTRA files in 1973. In 1988 the United States settled a suit brought by former patients. In 1992 the Canadian government compensated seventy-seven of them, who signed away further claims, and refused some two hundred and fifty others; in 2017 it settled with a patient's daughter under a non-disclosure agreement; and in 2025 the Superior Court of Quebec authorized a class action by former patients and their families against the Royal Victoria Hospital, McGill University, and the Attorney General of Canada.

Depatterning was Demolition carried out in fact, within a few years of Bester's novel, and without its fiction of rebirth: the erasure was achieved; the promised reconstruction was not. Psychic driving is Reich's jingle turned inside out. Reich installs a repeated phrase on the surface of his own mind to keep that mind his own; Cameron's patients had repeated phrases driven into minds that had first been emptied, to make them other than they were. The history also confirms the law of the opaque remainder from the side of the institution rather than the subject. The agencies that financed the reading and rewriting of minds made themselves illegible—through a front organization, through the destruction of files, through settlements conditioned on waivers and, as late as 2017, on silence. The asymmetry that Bester's Guild sanctified with a Pledge was administered here without one.

The therapeutic state also policed its heretics. Wilhelm Reich, whose characterology Chapter One set beside Ben Reich's jingle, established in Rangeley, Maine, an estate and laboratory he called Orgonon, from which he promoted the "orgone energy accumulator," a box he claimed could concentrate a universal life energy. In 1954 the Food and Drug Administration, whose complaint declared that orgone energy does not exist, obtained a federal injunction that banned the accumulators' interstate shipment, ordered their destruction along with the journals the court classed as their labeling, and required ten of Reich's books to be withheld from distribution until every reference to orgone had been removed. Reich, who had refused to answer the complaint in court on the ground that no court could adjudicate scientific findings, was convicted on 7 May 1956 of contempt for violating the injunction and sentenced to two years in prison. That summer the decree was carried out. Accumulators were destroyed at Orgonon in June and boxes of his publications burned there weeks later; on 23 August 1956, under FDA supervision, several tons of his publications were burned in a New York City sanitation incinerator—including, by the account of the trust that administers his estate, copies of books that had only been ordered withheld, such as *Character Analysis* and *The Mass Psychology of Fascism*. Reich entered the federal penitentiary at Lewisburg, Pennsylvania, in March 1957 and died there of heart failure on 3 November 1957.

Whatever one concludes about orgone, for which no scientific support has been found, the sequence completes this chapter's argument from the far side. In the decade of Bester's novel the American state imprisoned a psychoanalyst and burned his books, among them the treatise on character armor and the analysis of fascism's hold on the mass psyche, twenty-three years after the bonfires of May 1933 had consumed Freud's. Bester's Guild punishes its heretic by excommunication into opacity, the fate of Jerry Church; the actual therapeutic state of the 1950s, adjudicating which cures were legitimate, sent a heretic's words to the incinerator and his body to a cell. The two analysts whose names echo in Ben Reich's met opposite fates in that decade: Theodor Reik, theorist of the compulsion to confess, was practicing in New York, while Wilhelm Reich, theorist of the armor that resists confession, died in a federal prison.

5.4 *Literary Analogues of Therapeutic Unmaking*

The literature of the century returned obsessively to the remaking of the self by power. In Zamyatin's *We*, the One State's Great Operation excises the imagination by irradiating a center of the brain, and the narrator, operated upon, watches his former lover tortured without feeling. In Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), O'Brien empties Winston Smith of his former self and refills him until he loves the face of Big Brother. In Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962), the Ludovico Technique conditions Alex into aversion to violence, and the prison chaplain objects that a man who cannot choose has ceased to be a man. In Philip K. Dick's *A Scanner Darkly* (1977), the rehabilitation center New-Path turns out to cultivate, with the labor of its broken patients, the very plant from which the drug that broke them is made—rehabilitation as harvest. In Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919), the apparatus inscribes the sentence on the condemned man's body over twelve hours, and the officer promises a transfiguration at the sixth; Demolition, by contrast, erases in order to rewrite, a palimpsest inscribed on the soul. And in Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), the happiness of a utopian city depends on the suffering of a single child confined in darkness beneath it.

Against this archive Bester's novel is unique in that its therapeutic unmaking is presented without irony as the triumph of humane civilization. Zamyatin, Orwell, Burgess, and Dick present their procedures as horrors; Le Guin presents her sacrifice as the hidden price of joy. Bester presents Demolition as mercy, and the novel's final scenes are suffused with tenderness. That the tenderness and the horror cannot be separated is the novel's most unsettling achievement. In its last episode Powell brings the demolished man a box of sweets, as one brings candy to a child, and receives a burst of passionate gratitude, "Powell-friend," before wondering aloud whether being nursemaid to this crazy world is worth it (DM ch. 17, p. 239). The image is a benediction and an annihilation at once: the most powerful man in the solar system, the sovereign

who arrogated the right of death, has become an infant receiving a gift from his new father.

5.5 *The Old Man and the New: Paul, Lazarus, and Bloodless Violence*

The theological genealogy of Demolition is Pauline. "Knowing this, that our old man is crucified with him, that the body of sin might be destroyed" (Romans 6:6); "put off concerning the former conversation the old man ... and ... put on the new man" (Ephesians 4:22–24; compare Colossians 3:9–10). Baptism, for Paul, is a death and burial with Christ in order to rise into newness of life (Romans 6:3–4). The verb translated "destroyed" in Romans 6:6, *katargeō*, means more precisely to render inoperative, to deactivate; Giorgio Agamben's *The Time That Remains* (2000) made this *katargēsis* the key to Pauline messianism, a suspension that fulfills rather than annihilates. Demolition is a secular *katargēsis*: the old man is not killed but rendered inoperative, so that a new man may be put on. The novel's imagery of the fetal Reich in a garden after the mass cathexis is baptismal, and Dostoevsky's epilogue to *Crime and Punishment*, in which Raskolnikov begins his regeneration in Siberia after Sonya has read him the raising of Lazarus, is its nearest literary precedent. Demolition is Lazarus administered by a hospital.

The mass cathexis that precedes it is a secular Pentecost. In Acts 2, the Spirit descends upon an assembled community and enables each to understand the others across every barrier of language, reversing the confusion of Babel; the Guild's pooling of its psychic energy through a single channel is the descent of a collective spirit upon one man. Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" distinguished the mythic violence that founds and preserves law, and that is bloody, from a divine violence that destroys law, expiates, and is lethal without the shedding of blood. Demolition is bloodless and lethal to the person, and in this it resembles Benjamin's divine violence; but it preserves the legal order rather than abolishing it, and in this it remains mythic. It is the therapeutic simulacrum of divine violence: law-preserving force that has borrowed the bloodlessness of the sacred. The bloodlessness is not innocence. Discovering Reich's secret, Powell says he would twist Reich's head off and hang him on a galactic gallows if he could, and that had he known of the booby-traps sooner he would have broken his conditioning and killed him (DM ch. 14, pp. 190–191). Demolition sublimates the detective's own wish to execute.

5.6 *Personal Capital Punishment and the Labor of Re-facement*

The decisive philosophical question is who, after Demolition, has been punished. Locke's chapter "Of Identity and Diversity" in the *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (2nd ed., 1694, II.xxvii) located personal identity in the continuity of consciousness

through memory, and called "person" a forensic term, one that appropriates actions and their merit and so applies only to agents capable of a law. On the Lockean criterion, which underwrites the modern juridical concept of responsibility, a being who retains the body but none of the memories of the criminal is not the same person. Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) refined the point: what matters in survival is psychological connectedness and continuity, and a procedure that severs them leaves no one who survives in the sense that matters. By these criteria Demolition does not reform Reich. It ends him, and produces another person in his body. The society that has abolished the death penalty has abolished it only for bodies. For persons it remains in force, administered by injection and called therapy. I name this *personal capital punishment*, and I regard it as the novel's most profound and least acknowledged discovery.

The constructive phase of the procedure completes the logic. Paul de Man's "Autobiography as De-facement" (1979) identified prosopopoeia—the figure that confers a face and a voice upon the absent, the dead, or the voiceless—as the master trope of self-representation, and argued that the face it gives is always also a defacement. Demolition institutionalizes prosopopoeia. The polity that has rendered faces superfluous as media of knowledge must nonetheless produce persons, and so it becomes a manufactory of faces: it de-faces the criminal and re-faces the body. I call this phase *re-facement*. Its economic rationale is the one that Theodore Schultz (1961) and Gary Becker (1964) would soon formalize as human capital—the person as a store of productive capacities in which a society invests—and Demolition is the write-down and recapitalization of a human asset too valuable to scrap. Kingston's physician states the rationale in the novel's final pages: a man with the talent and nerve to buck society is above average, so one straightens him out and turns him into a "plus value"—the French term for surplus value—rather than throwing him away, since a society that killed such men would be left with nothing but sheep (DM ch. 17, p. 238). Nietzsche's herd and Marx's surplus value meet in a single sentence of therapeutic reassurance. Philip Rieff's *The Triumph of the Therapeutic* (1966) described a culture in which therapy replaces salvation as the horizon of the self; Demolition is the triumph of the therapeutic in penology, and its tenderness is the tenderness of an institution that loves the capacities of the man it has erased.

CHAPTER

6

The Man With No Face

A Fourfold Exegesis

The Man With No Face is the novel's master trope, and its overdetermination is so dense that no single interpretive register exhausts it. This chapter therefore submits the figure to the fourfold exegesis of the medieval schools, demonstrating that it signifies, in the literal sense, the unrepresentable face of an unknown father; in the allegorical sense, the faceless sovereignty of the telepathic commons; in the tropological sense, the call of a conscience that precedes the crime; and in the anagogical sense, the deferred eschatological promise of knowing "face to face."

The narrative facts are few and exact. Reich's nightmares of the faceless figure precede the murder: ninety-seven of them in six months, by his analyst's count, in a recurring triptych of a bank vault blown open, a train to Paris, and a song performed on a marble stage to an empty amphitheater whose only spectator is the faceless man, watching in silence (DM ch. 1, pp. 11–15). The analyst, a Second Class Esper, traces the dreams to the D'Courtney Cartel and tells Reich that the figure is faceless because he is rejecting a face he knows; Reich concludes that it is the face of murder; Tate, a First Class Esper, tells him that it is not a symbol of murder and withholds the rest as leverage (chs. 1–2, pp. 15–16, 30–31). The figure persecutes him throughout the pursuit, and the attempts on his life that the narrative first attributes to an unknown assassin are revealed to be his own, executed in somnambulistic fugue. It sits as judge, in wig and gown, in a later nightmare (ch. 14, p. 176); it appears in the waking world, crossing a rain-swept square, behind an observatory telescope, and behind the grille of a travel office, where those who look for Reich's tormentor find an ordinary doctor, a bald man of sixty, a clerk (chs. 15–16). The novel is explicit that the facelessness lies in the per-

ceiver: asked what the doctor's face looks like, Duffy Wyg& answers that it is a face, with two eyes and two lips (ch. 16, p. 208). At the climax of the mass cathexis, alone in a universe from which every star and planet has been subtracted, Reich confronts the figure and sees at last its face: his own, merged with D'Courtney's. The names merge with the faces—Ben D'Courtney, Craye Reich, the monogram D'R—and the figure speaks as the father-part of Reich: it planted the booby-traps without passion, for survival, and Reich has lost the cosmic game by winning the world (ch. 16, pp. 225–226). Powell's own explanation in the last chapter is that the figure had no face because Reich could not accept that he had recognized D'Courtney as his father (ch. 17, p. 231).

The hermeneutic chosen to read these facts requires a word of justification. John Cassian's *Conferences* (XIV.8) taught that Jerusalem signifies, literally, the city of the Jews; allegorically, the Church; tropologically, the soul; and anagogically, the heavenly city. Aquinas systematized the senses in the *Summa Theologiae* (I.1.10), Dante invoked them in the letter to Cangrande, and a thirteenth-century distich attributed to Augustine of Dacia compressed them into a mnemonic: *littera gesta docet, quid credas allegoria, / moralis quid agas, quo tendas anagogia*—the letter teaches what happened, allegory what to believe, the moral sense what to do, anagogy where one is going. The patristic quadriga is a premodern theory of overdetermination, homologous to the principle Freud formulated in *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1900), that every element of the manifest dream is the nodal point of several dream-thoughts. To read Bester's figure fourfold is to apply to a science-fiction villain the hermeneutics that both the Church and psychoanalysis reserved for their most sacred texts.

6.1 Sensus Litteralis*: The Unrepresentable Father*

At the level of the letter, the Man With No Face is a dream-figure, produced by the dream-work Freud anatomized: condensation, displacement, considerations of representability, and secondary revision. The novel's own analysts disagree about the mechanism, and the disagreement is instructive. Breen holds that Reich rejects a face he knows; Powell, at the end, that Reich could not accept that he had recognized D'Courtney as his father. Both describe what Freud called negation: a recognition already made at one level is refused at another, and the dream represents the refused recognition by the absence of a face. The figure is faceless not because the face is unknown but because the recognition it would compel is unbearable—which is why, in the waking hallucinations, men with perfectly ordinary features appear to Reich without faces at all. When the mass cathexis finally confers representability upon the relation, the face appears—and it is double.

Ernest Jones's *On the Nightmare* (1931) traced the incubus of folklore, the oppressive visitor who sits upon the sleeper's chest, to the return of repressed incestuous wishes; Reich's faceless persecutor belongs to that lineage, the nocturnal form of a relation the

waking mind cannot bear. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) and Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914) identified the double as a figure that begins as insurance against death and ends as its harbinger. The literary ancestry is distinguished. Poe's "William Wilson" (1839) gives the narrator a double who shares his name and face, and whom he cannot kill without killing himself. Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) gives the double a face that cannot be described: Enfield reports of Hyde that "he gives a strong feeling of deformity, although I couldn't specify the point." Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890) externalizes the soul's crimes onto a portrait, which Dorian stabs, thereby killing himself; Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846) and Ivan Karamazov's devil complete the series. Bester's figure is the limit case of the tradition: where Poe's double has the subject's face, Hyde's has an indescribable face, and Dorian's portrait has a face that records everything, the Man With No Face has none at all, until the moment when it has two. The novel supplies the chiasmus that completes the pattern: the detective has a double of his own, the fabulist Dishonest Abe, so that the criminal is haunted by a double who embodies the truth he denies and the detective by a double who embodies the lies he cannot help telling.

The figure belongs, moreover, to an economy of sight that pervades the novel. Espers are called "Peepers," a term that carries the voyeur's furtive scopophilia; Reich blinds D'Courtney's guards with a Rhodopsin Ionizer, a device that destroys the visual purple of the retina; the underworld agent he hires to find Barbara, Keno Quizzard, is a blind croupier. E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), the tale on which Freud based his theory of the uncanny, links, in Freud's reading, the dread of losing one's eyes to the dread of castration at the father's hands—Oedipus's self-blinding being, Freud adds, a mitigated form of that punishment, the parricide's sentence executed on the organ of sight; Bester's novel distributes eyes and blindness across its characters with a consistency that makes the faceless man—a face without eyes—their culmination. The list is longer than a summary suggests. Keno Quizzard, the blind croupier, sexually abuses the catatonic Barbara while compelling his wife to serve as his eyes and describe the scene; Reich watches them unseen through the crystal floor of Chooka Frood's voyeur chamber; Quizzard's wife claws at Powell's eyes; Mary Noyes's rebus at the Esper party resolves into an eye in a stein; and a cab driver adjusted at Kingston explains delusion as the conviction that people once had one eye and suddenly have two (DM chs. 3, 9, 16, pp. 38, 119, 214–215). It is a watching child, finally, who stops a murder: about to kill the paralyzed Mary Noyes, Reich is halted three times by the sense that someone is watching him, and finds Barbara peering through the banisters (ch. 14, p. 185). Jacques Lacan's "mirror stage" (1949) located the origin of the ego in the infant's jubilant identification with its specular image. The faceless man is the failure of the mirror, and its final face is the mirror's belated success. But what the mirror shows is not Reich alone. Freud wrote in *The Ego and the Id* (1923) that

the character of the ego is a precipitate of abandoned object-cathexes, containing the history of its object-choices. The father's face fused with Reich's own is that precipitate made visible: the ego of the abandoned son is built around the father who abandoned him.

6.2 Sensus Allegoricus*: The Faceless Sovereign*

The frontispiece of Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651), engraved by Abraham Bosse, depicts the sovereign as a giant whose body is composed of hundreds of small human figures, all turned toward the sovereign's head, so that the viewer sees only their backs. The subjects have no faces; the sovereign alone has a countenance. Diaphanocracy inverts the image. Its subjects are transparent, read through and through, while its sovereign—the Guild, the collective, the commons that acts through the mass cathexis—has no face, because it is not a person but a pooled power. In the allegorical sense the Man With No Face is the Leviathan of the telepathic commons: a mortal god without a countenance, whose pursuit of Reich through his own nights anticipates the collective that will finally unmake him. Bester's own imagery points the same way: in a later nightmare the faceless man presides from the bench in wig and gown (DM ch. 14, p. 176), and the faceless law of the dream is answered, in the waking plot, by a law-machine with a hundred eyes. Walter Benjamin's formless, spectral police and Lacan's big Other, the symbolic order that speaks through every subject and is embodied in none, are its theoretical names; Shoshana Zuboff's "Big Other" is its contemporary avatar.

The most exact philosophical gloss is Heidegger's. In *Being and Time* (§27), the everyday self is absorbed into *das Man*, the anonymous "they" or "one" of public existence, of which Heidegger writes: *Jeder ist der Andere und Keiner er selbst*—everyone is the other, and no one is himself. *Das Man* is, in his own term, the "nobody." The coincidence that the English title of Bester's figure contains the German name of this faceless anonymity is accidental; the conceptual correspondence is not. Diaphanocracy is *das Man* perfected: a public in which every mind is available to the reading of others and in which no one, therefore, is himself. The Man With No Face is *das Man* encountered in the night, the anonymous power of the public turned persecutor. Reich supplies the word himself. When a cab driver reports that the faceless figure behind the observatory telescope is an ordinary bald man, Reich mutters that it is nobody, nobody (DM ch. 16, p. 214).

The Mosaic thread of the allegory runs back to Exodus. When Moses asks to see the glory of God, he is told: "Thou canst not see my face: for there shall no man see me, and live" (Exodus 33:20); he is permitted to see only the divine back as it passes (33:23). The sovereign whose face cannot be seen is the God of the law that Old Man Mose mechanizes. At the climax Reich sees the face—and, by the measure of the previ-

ous chapter, he does not live: the person who saw it will be erased. The Mosaic interdict is fulfilled to the letter.

6.3 Sensus Tropologicus*: The Call of Conscience*

In the moral sense, the Man With No Face is conscience. Freud's *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) described culture's mastery of the individual's aggressiveness as the installation within him of an agency that watches over it "like a garrison in a conquered city." The faceless man is that garrison, and the novel lets it act: the somnambulistic sabotage is the superego taking up arms. Georg Groddeck's *Das Buch vom Es* (1923), from which Freud borrowed the term *das Es*, described the It as the impersonal force by which we are lived rather than the self by which we live; the It is faceless by definition. Freud's maxim from the *New Introductory Lectures* (1933)—*Wo Es war, soll Ich werden*, where It was, there I shall come to be—finds a literal staging at the climax, where the faceless It acquires Reich's own face. Lacan's rereading of the maxim as an imperative to arrive at the place of one's own unconscious truth describes the trajectory of the mass cathexis exactly; that the face which arrives is also the father's is the novel's correction of the ego-psychological optimism of its own decade, which read the maxim as the conquest of the id by an adaptive ego.

Heidegger's analysis of conscience (*Being and Time*, §§54–60) supplies the tropological sense its fullest articulation. The call of conscience, he argues, comes from Dasein itself in its uncanniness, yet it comes as if from beyond; the caller has no worldly identity and cannot be characterized by anything familiar; and what it discloses is Dasein's being-guilty (*Schuldigsein*), a guilt that is not derived from any particular debt or transgression but precedes them all (§58). The convergence with Freud is remarkable. For Freud, the criminal's sense of guilt precedes his crime; for Heidegger, being-guilty precedes every determinate fault. The Man With No Face, who appears before the murder and calls Reich from his lostness in the entrepreneurial they-self of Monarch toward the guilt he cannot name, is the novel's figure for this anteriority of guilt to deed. Rimbaud's formula of 1871, *Je est un autre*—I is an other—names its final disclosure: the persecutor is the self, and the self is constituted by an other it does not know. At the climax the figure says as much: it is the part of Reich that understands, driven from him by every corruption in him, and it tried to destroy him in order to save them both (DM ch. 16, pp. 225–226). The novel stages a second conscience beside Reich's. Hanging from a light bracket under a harmonic-gun attack, the corrupted First Class Esper Augustus Tate lets go and is killed, and the narration names the cause as a death compulsion that no Guild conditioning could have prevented (ch. 11, p. 145).

6.4 Sensus Anagogicus*: The Eschaton of the Face*

In the anagogical sense, the figure points toward the end. The thirteenth chapter of Paul's first letter to the Corinthians, the hymn to love, culminates in an eschatological promise: "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known" (1 Corinthians 13:12). Telepathy is the secular realization of the second clause—to know as one is known, in a reciprocal transparency that Paul locates at the end of time—and Powell's prophecy at the novel's close, of a humanity joined in a communion of minds and hearts, is 1 Corinthians 13 in futurological idiom, binding transparency to love exactly as Paul did. The second letter supplies the counter-image. Contrasting the veil that Moses wore over his shining face with the unveiled faces of the faithful, Paul writes that "we all, with open face beholding as in a glass the glory of the Lord, are changed into the same image" (2 Corinthians 3:18). The climax of the mass cathexis is a dark parody of this transformation: Reich, unveiled at last, beholds a face into which his own and his father's have been changed into the same image.

Emmanuel Levinas, writing in Paris in the same years that Bester wrote in New York, was beginning to articulate in essays such as "Is Ontology Fundamental?" (1951) the ethics he would systematize in *Totality and Infinity* (1961). The face of the Other, for Levinas, is an epiphany whose first signification is the commandment not to kill; murder is the one act that aims at the Other precisely as Other, which is why the Other is the only being one can wish to kill; and the face resists every attempt to reduce the Other to what can be known, because its alterity is infinite. The preface to *Totality and Infinity* opposes to the totality of war an "eschatology of messianic peace." Read through Levinas, the Man With No Face is double-coded. It is the emblem of Reich's world, a world in which the Other has no face and in which, therefore, the ethical interdiction has lapsed and murder has become possible. But it is equally the emblem of the Guild's world, in which the Other is known totally, read through and through, and in which the face has become superfluous. Telepathic transparency is, in Levinas's vocabulary, totality: the reduction of the Other to the Same through knowledge. The novel's anagogical crisis is the collision of two eschatologies—Paul's, in which the end is to know as one is known, and Levinas's, in which the end is a peace that never abolishes the infinity of the face. Bester's narrative chooses Paul; its central figure testifies for Levinas. The plot itself contains the Levinasian scene. At Chooka Frood's, Reich, invisible above the crystal floor with his weapon trained on Powell's skull, cannot fire: Powell, holding Barbara, turns his face up toward the man he cannot see and dares him to shoot, and Reich lowers his eyes and turns his face away (DM ch. 9, p. 121). Powell later admits that he does not know why Reich could not kill (ch. 10, p. 125); Levinas's account of the face explains what the detective's telepathy cannot. The love story turns on the face as well: when Powell lies to Barbara, a normal, that he does not love her, let-

ting Dishonest Abe arrange a kind and patronizing expression, she reads the lie in his face (ch. 15, p. 204).

The novel's frame makes the anagogical sense explicit. It opens and closes with the same cosmic meditation: what seems exceptional to the minute mind of man is inevitable to the infinite Eye of God, and every event recurs on a galaxy that has revolved nine times already. The prologue introduces Reich's story as that of one more man afflicted with the megalomania of believing himself unique, irreplaceable, irreproducible; the epilogue repeats the meditation in the past tense and ends by promising that there has been joy and will be joy again (DM prologue; p. 239). The novel is thus bracketed by a total gaze and by eternal recurrence—Nietzsche's doctrine, which Zarathustra affirms in the knowledge that all joy wants eternity. Between the brackets, at the bottom of the de-created universe, the faceless man pronounces the opposite of both: there is no space, no time, and no God (ch. 16, p. 225). And Powell's last words split the novel's eschatology in two. To the Commissioner he describes the telepath's life as a life in a psychiatric ward and tells him to be grateful that he sees only the outward man and is blind—Paul's term for the perishing body (2 Corinthians 4:16)—before privately congratulating himself on the effectiveness of the line (ch. 17, p. 233). To the normals, in the novel's last speech, he cries that they must tear the veils away until all are joined mind to mind (p. 239). Grateful blindness and torn veils: the novel's two eschatologies are delivered by the same man within six pages.

The science-fictional archive confirms the stakes of the face at the end of history. In Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953), the Overlords conceal their appearance from humanity for fifty years, because they resemble the devils of human tradition; the novel's eschaton, the absorption of humanity's last children into the Overmind, ends individuality itself. In Philip K. Dick's *A Scanner Darkly*, whose title paraphrases 1 Corinthians 13:12, the narcotics agent Fred wears a scramble suit that renders him a shifting blur of anonymous faces, and is assigned to surveil his own other self, Bob Arctor, without knowing it: self-surveillance by a faceless self is Dick's version of Reich's persecution. In Algis Budrys's *Who?* (1958), a physicist returned from Soviet captivity with a metal prosthesis in place of his head and face confronts a security apparatus that can never verify who he is: the Cold War's man with no face. And in Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961), the oceanic intelligence that reads the minds of the station's crew gives guilt a face, materializing for the psychologist Kelvin the simulacrum of the woman whose suicide he caused. Lem's guilt wears the beloved's face; Bester's wears none until it wears the father's. The two novels occupy the opposite poles of the anagogical sense.

6.5 *Bester's Prosopological Diptych*

Bester's second great novel, *The Stars My Destination* (1956; published in Britain as *Tiger! Tiger!*), forms with the first a diptych on the face. Gully Foyle's face is tattooed with the mask of a tiger by the scavenging tribe of the Sargasso Asteroid; the tattoo is removed, but its scars return whenever he is seized by rage or passion, so that his face becomes the involuntary text of his drives. *The Demolished Man* gives us a man with no face; *The Stars My Destination* gives us a man with too much face. In the first novel the inner life is legible to telepaths and the face is effaced; in the second there are no telepaths, and the face itself becomes the medium through which the id writes itself on the world. Between them the two novels bracket Bester's problem: in an order of transparency, the face is either abolished or it returns as stigma. The story "Fondly Fahrenheit" (1954), whose narration slides between a man and his murderous android, between "I" and "we," until the reader cannot assign the killings to either, completes the triptych: the criminal subject as a shared and faceless first person.

6.6 *Synthesis: Prosopocide and the Law of the Opaque Remainder*

The four senses converge. Literally, the Man With No Face is the father whom the son could not represent; allegorically, it is the collective sovereign that has no countenance; tropologically, it is the conscience whose guilt precedes the deed; anagogically, it is the face-to-face that transparency promises and that the face, in its infinity, refuses. Its final disclosure—Reich's face merged with D'Courtney's—identifies what the transparent society could not read. It was not a content in Reich's mind, a secret intention concealed beneath the jingle. It was a relation: the son's unknown identification with the father who abandoned him. The remainder was genealogical, structural, formal. Some readers infer, from the latent telepathy the novel discovers in Reich's half-sister, that his hatred rested on a latent, unconscious knowledge of his paternity. The text leaves the matter unstated, and the law of the opaque remainder explains why it must: a knowledge that could be stated would no longer be the remainder.

The law of the opaque remainder can now be stated in full. In any order that renders the contents of minds legible, the irreducibly opaque migrates from content to the relations that constitute minds—genealogy, structure, form—and returns as a crime whose author is unknown even to himself. The order responds by personifying the remainder as a faceless enemy and consuming it in a rite of unanimous therapeutic violence, through which the order reaffirms its own unity. Durkheim had argued, in *The Rules of Sociological Method* (1895, ch. III), that crime is normal: even a society of saints, a perfect cloister of exemplary individuals, would treat as crimes the faults that ordinary consciences find venial, because the collective conscience requires transgression in order to feel itself. The law of the opaque remainder is the epistemic counterpart of

Durkheim's sociological law. Deviance is conserved under virtue; opacity is conserved under transparency. Prosopocide—the effacement of the face in the murder, in the telepathic order, and in Demolition—is the price diaphanocracy pays for its transparency, and the Man With No Face is the receipt. Bester's text chose the word first. Among the capitalized commands through which the mass cathexis dismantles Reich's universe is EFFACE, issued once for the particles of matter and once more just before a sentence that breaks off at THE SUBJECT WILL BE (DM ch. 16, pp. 206, 222). The subject's predicate is left blank; Demolition will supply it.

CHAPTER

7

The Telepathic Archive

Comparative Constellations in Speculative and Philosophical Fiction

Within the archive of twentieth-century speculative and philosophical fiction, *The Demolished Man* occupies a hinge position between the dystopias of transparency, which imagine the legible mind as tyranny, and the fictions of the group mind, which imagine it as apotheosis: Bester alone imagines telepathy as a profession, and his distinctive contribution is the routinization of transparency into an institution with classes, a pledge, courts, and a computer. This chapter maps the archive by problem rather than chronology, in five constellations.

7.1 *The Telepath as Minority*

A. E. van Vogt's *Slan* (serialized 1940; book 1946) established the telepath as a persecuted minority: mutants marked by the tendrils through which they read minds, hunted by a normal majority that fears its successors. Henry Kuttner and C. L. Moore's "Baldy" stories, collected as *Mutant* (1953), refined the figure into something much closer to Bester's Guild: hairless telepaths who wear wigs in order to pass among normals, bound to one another by an ethic of restraint and threatened from within by a paranoid faction that dreams of telepathic supremacy. The Baldies' internal schism anticipates the Tate episode precisely, and their wigs anticipate the jingle: both are prostheses of concealment. John Wyndham's *The Midwich Cuckoos* (1957) inverted the moral polarity. Its telepathic children share a single collective mind and are destroyed by the village sage who has befriended them; in the 1960 film adaptation, *Village of the Damned*, he shields his lethal intent by fixing his mind on the image of a brick wall.

Wyndham's mental shield, like Reich's jingle, protects a killing from telepathic detection, but in Wyndham's Cold War fable the killing is heroic and the collective mind is the alien threat, legible as an allegory of the communist collective. Bester's commons is liberal and professional; Wyndham's is alien and total; and the two novels divide between them the ambivalence of the decade toward the very idea of shared mind. Robert Silverberg's *Dying Inside* (1972), finally, gives the telepath's own melancholy: David Selig experiences his fading gift as voyeurism and isolation rather than communion, the obverse of everything the Guild promises.

7.2 *The Group Mind and the End of the Individual*

Olaf Stapledon's *Odd John* (1935) imagined a superman who gathers a colony of telepathic supernormals and chooses its destruction over submission to the normal world; *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937) extended telepathic communion to the scale of species and galaxies. Theodore Sturgeon's *More Than Human* (1953), published the same year as Bester's book, imagines *homo gestalt*, a composite being formed from a group of damaged children, whose maturity requires the acquisition not of morals, which govern individuals within a society, but of an ethos proper to a new kind of being. Sturgeon's gestalt is already a person; Bester's Guild is a professional association that aspires, through its eugenic program, to become one. Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) carries the aspiration to its end: humanity's last children are absorbed into the Overmind, and the individual ceases to exist.

Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) offers the most searching critique of communion. Its religion, Mercerism, fuses believers through an empathy box into a shared experience of the suffering of Wilbur Mercer; when Mercer is exposed as an actor on a soundstage, the communion nonetheless persists, as though its truth lay in its effects rather than its origin. The mass cathexis is a manufactured communion in the same sense, a delusion constructed by Powell and dismantled for therapeutic ends. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) supplies the most delicate counter-image. When the envoy Genly Ai teaches the Gethenian Estraven to mindspeak, Estraven hears the envoy's inner voice in the voice of his dead brother. Telepathy, in Le Guin, is haunted by prosopopoeia: the mind of the living speaks with the voice of the dead. The comparison illuminates the cry that wakes Barbara on the night of the murder, a cry her voiceless father could only have sent telepathically. In both novels the telepathic voice is the voice of the dead or the dying, and the communion of minds is shadowed by mourning.

7.3 *Precrime and the Policing of Intention*

Philip K. Dick's "The Minority Report" (1956) moved the policing of intention from the present into the future. Three precognitive mutants foresee crimes, and their majority report licenses the arrest of those who have not yet acted; the dissenting minority report reveals that the future can be otherwise. The minority report is the opaque remainder of precognition, the residue of contingency that a predictive order must suppress in order to function. Where Bester's Espers read present intentions, Dick's precogs read future acts; both abolish the interval between intention and deed in which, for the liberal tradition, freedom and responsibility reside. Steven Spielberg's film adaptation (2002) translated precrime into the idiom of biometric capitalism, with retinal scans that identify citizens to both police and advertisers: the eye replaces the face as the site at which the person is captured. Isaac Asimov's *The Caves of Steel* (1953–1954) answered the charge that science-fiction mysteries could not play fair by constructing a rigorously fair-play puzzle around a robot detective constrained by the Laws of Robotics. Asimov secured the genre's fairness by constraining his detective's mind; Bester secured his novel's suspense by exposing his criminal's mind and locating the mystery in a place no constraint could reach.

7.4 *The Guild, the Breeding Program, and Routinized Charisma*

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) divided the functions of Bester's Guild between two institutions. The Bene Gesserit pursue a centuries-long breeding program toward a superbeing and supply the Truthsayers who detect lies at court; the Spacing Guild holds a monopoly on a cognitive service—prescient navigation—on which the entire imperial economy depends. Bester's Esper Guild unites both: it breeds for telepathy and it monopolizes the reading of minds on which the solar economy's justice depends. Asimov's Second Foundation, a hidden fraternity of mentalics guarding the statistical science of history, and Heinlein's Howard Families, bred for longevity, complete the family of eugenic fraternities in mid-century science fiction.

Max Weber's concept of the routinization of charisma (*Economy and Society*, 1922)—the transformation of an extraordinary personal gift into a stable institution with offices, rules, and succession—names what is distinctive in Bester's achievement within this family. Telepathy in *Slan* is a mutant's charisma; in Stapledon and Clarke it is the charisma of a species at the threshold of transcendence. In *The Demolished Man* it has been routinized into a professional estate with examinations, classes, ethics committees, and disciplinary expulsions. The mass cathexis is the moment in which routinized charisma becomes charismatic again—the institution, in extremity, recovering the collective extraordinariness from which it arose—and its dangerousness, its history of killing its channel, marks the cost of that recovery.

7.5 *The Philosophical Novel of Guilt and Visibility*

The philosophical novel of guilt from Dostoevsky to Kafka supplied Bester with the structure of the criminal's self-betrayal and the inscrutability of the law; the dystopian novel of transparency supplied the political image of the legible society. Zamyatin's *We* imagined glass dwellings and a surgical excision of the imagination. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) imagined hypnopaedia, the repetition of slogans to sleeping children until the mind is furnished with them; Reich's jingle is self-administered hypnopaedia turned to the opposite purpose, a repetition installed not to receive social programming but to repel social reading. Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* is the decisive point of comparison. In Oceania the face is still the medium of surveillance: the telescreens watch expressions, and Newspeak has a word, *facecrime*, for wearing an improper expression. Orwell's novel is the last great fiction of the physiognomic police; Bester's, published four years later, is the first fiction of the post-facial police, in which facecrime has become obsolete because the police no longer need the face.

Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man*, published in 1952, the year of Bester's serialization, inverts the economy of visibility from another direction. Ellison's narrator is invisible because others refuse to see him: invisibility is not a technique of evasion but a condition imposed by white America's refusal to see its Black citizens, enforced in the South by the legal regime of segregation and sustained across the country by discrimination and violence. Reich hides by choice from a society that sees too much; Ellison's narrator is hidden against his will by a society that sees too little. Bester's 2301 is largely unmarked by race, and where race appears it appears as the Guild's universalism, rendered in the stereotyped idiom of its moment: the Guild's president is a Chinese "mandarin," a "Japanese team" of researchers is caricatured, and the one Black character, a young man waiting in line at the Guild Institute, is discovered to be a latent telepath and welcomed with congratulations (DM chs. 7, 10, pp. 93–94, 135). The novel imagines the color line crossed by the gift rather than abolished by justice, and its near-silence on the question is audible against Ellison's novel. Any account of the politics of transparency must reckon with the fact that visibility has never been distributed equally, and that the right to be seen and the right not to be seen have been allotted, historically, along the lines of power.

7.6 *The Place of* The Demolished Man

The constellations converge on a single determination. The dystopias of transparency —Zamyatin, Huxley, Orwell—present the legible mind as the achievement of tyranny; the transcendence fictions—Stapledon, Sturgeon, Clarke—present it as the destiny of evolution; the minority fictions—van Vogt, Kuttner and Moore, Wyndham, Silverberg —present it as the burden of a caste. *The Demolished Man* presents it as a profession,

embedded in law, medicine, and commerce, and in doing so it anticipates the actual form that the transparency of minds has taken in the twenty-first century: not the omnipotence of a dictator nor the apotheosis of a species but the routine operations of credentialed institutions and their machines. Its utopianism lies in its confidence that such institutions can be bound by a pledge; its prophetic accuracy lies in its recognition that they will be.

CHAPTER

8

The Typographic Face

Form, Style, and Telepathic Narration

Bester's typography is the novel's own face: in a fiction that renders the face obsolete as a medium of knowledge, the page reasserts a visible surface that must be looked at before it can be read, and on that surface the novel performs upon its reader an argument about opacity that its plot resolves in the opposite direction.

8.1 *The Page as Field*

The devices are well known and usually admired as ornament. Proper names in 2301 incorporate typographic characters—Duffy Wyg&, Sam @kins, ¼Maine—as though the fashions of the future had reached the orthography of persons. When Jerry Church is designated by his telepathic rank, the numeral of his former class is struck through on the page, so that his expulsion from the Guild is inscribed in the typography of his name. The jingle that armors Reich's mind is printed in the text and recurs at moments of maximum pressure, interrupting the narration as it interrupts the probing Espers. And at the party in Powell's house, where the Guild's members converse telepathically, Bester sets the simultaneous exchanges in interlaced, spatially arranged typography, so that several threads of conversation can be followed across the page at once. These devices belong to a lineage of typographic experiment—the black and marbled pages of Sterne's *Tristram Shandy* (1759–1767), the tail-shaped "Mouse's Tale" of Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (1865), Mallarmé's *Un coup de dés* (1897), Apollinaire's *Calligrammes* (1918), the Newsreel and Camera Eye montages of Dos Passos's *U.S.A.*

(1930–1936)—and, more immediately, to the panel grammar of the comic book in which Bester served his apprenticeship.

Their function is specific. Ferdinand de Saussure held, as the second principle of the *Cours de linguistique générale* (1916), that the linguistic signifier is linear: it unfolds in time, one element after another. Telepathic exchange, as Bester conceives it, is simultaneous and multidirectional, a field of minds in mutual presence. The typography of the Esper party is a graphic critique of the linearity of the signifier, converting the page from a line into a field in order to represent a communication the line cannot hold. The names achieve a converse effect. The proper name is the most facial element of language, the word that designates a singular person, and Bester's glyphic names cannot be fully spoken, only seen. They give the name a face on the page that the voice cannot reproduce—a grammatological joke, in the sense of Derrida's *De la grammatologie* (1967), in a novel about the supersession of the voice by direct mental access, and a reminder that writing was never merely the transcription of speech. The struck-through numeral of Church's rank is the limiting case: excommunication rendered as a typographic wound. The catalogue is richer than commentary usually admits. At the Esper party Mary Noyes weaves the opening lines of Matthew Arnold's "Dover Beach"—the Victorian elegy for the ebbing Sea of Faith, which ends in a plea for love—into a picture-poem whose solution is an eye in a stein (DM ch. 3, p. 38). In telepathic speech a lawyer can embed his client's name inside a word, "cli(Ben Reich)ent" (ch. 6, p. 73), and when Powell and Beck trade insults the text censors them in mid-word, "Sar(censored)castic" (p. 85)—the transparent mind meeting the printer's veil. Barbara's unconscious couples her to her brother as "B & B"; Mary's farewell dissolves the names of their friends into a row of ampersands; the Council's two-minute emergency session is printed as a sequence of images ending with a clock whose second hand points at Demolition; and the de-creation of Reich's universe is set as capitalized imperatives—ABOLISH, DELETE, EFFACE, ERASE—with equations and lists in parentheses (chs. 11, 15, 16). The ampersand, which began as a joke in Duffy Wyg&'s name, ends as the sign of the commons.

Marshall McLuhan's *The Mechanical Bride* (1951), published while Bester was writing, read advertisements, comic strips, and detective fiction as the folklore of industrial man. *The Demolished Man* is that folklore become self-conscious: a detective story built around an advertising jingle and set in the visual idiom of the comics. McLuhan would later describe electric media as an outward extension of the central nervous system (*Understanding Media*, 1964); telepathy is that extension accomplished without a medium, and Bester's typography is the trace of the medium that the fiction abolishes.

8.2 *Transparent Minds: Telepathy as Narration*

Dorrit Cohn's *Transparent Minds* (1978) argued that narrative fiction is the only literary genre, indeed the only kind of discourse, in which the unspoken thoughts and feelings of a person other than the speaker can be portrayed, and that this privilege defines the novel. Nicholas Royle has proposed that the narrator conventionally called omniscient is better described as telepathic (Royle 1991, 2003). Read through these accounts, Bester's Espers are the diegetic projection of the novelist's own privilege, and diaphanocracy is the condition of fiction itself: the novel was the first transparent society, a world in which every mind lies open to a reading consciousness not its own. Bester's narrator moves between Reich's mind and Powell's with the ease with which a First Class Esper descends through the strata of the unconscious, and the analogy is made reflexive at every turn.

The jingle, in this light, is a character's resistance to narration—a figure trying to hide from the omniscience that constitutes him. When the text prints the jingle, the reader stands exactly where the Espers stand, blocked by a surface of noise; the reader is made a Peeper and frustrated as one. The novel also stages violence against the page. Reich's first act of murder is the mutilation of an antique printed game book, which the bookshop of 2301 treats as a curiosity from the age of the visual book: he spends three hours defacing it with heat, acid, stain, and scissors, each cut a proxy blow against D'Courtney, until only the game of Sardine survives (DM ch. 4, pp. 42–43). Prosopocide begins as the defacement of a book. Its counterpart comes when Powell, learning that WWHG meant acceptance, twists the head off the android figure of Reich in the District Attorney's model of the crime (ch. 13, p. 174). And the text performs Barbara's repetition compulsion on itself: each time she relives the murder, the narration repeats, word for word, the sentences in which it first described her bursting into the orchid room (chs. 5, 9, 14). Demolition acquires a corresponding metafictional sense. It is the author's power to unmake a character and write him again, preserving his energy while erasing his history: the editorial fantasy of Gold's *Galaxy* (Chapter One) raised to a penal ideal. The detective shares the author's vice. Powell's Dishonest Abe moods produce imaginary persons on demand, including a heroic Lieutenant Kopenick whom the Commissioner wishes to decorate (DM ch. 3, p. 32)—an allusion, conscious or not, to the Captain of Köpenick, the impostor who in 1906 commandeered a Prussian town hall in a borrowed uniform. The man who will remake Reich is introduced as a maker of fictitious persons. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics* (1929; revised 1963) argued that Dostoevsky's heroes resist the author's final word about them, that the polyphonic novel refuses to finalize persons who never wholly coincide with themselves. *The Demolished Man* stages the conflict between polyphony and finalization within its plot. Reich's jingle is his insistence on his own word against every reading of him; Demolition is the most absolute finalization imaginable, an autho-

rial last word written directly into a mind. A novel that owes its psychological duel to Dostoevsky ends by doing to its hero what Dostoevsky's poetics forbade.

8.3 *The Face of the Text*

In 1930 the typographer Beatrice Warde delivered the lecture later published as "The Crystal Goblet, or Printing Should Be Invisible," which became the creed of modern book typography: the ideal page is a clear glass that reveals the wine it holds and draws no attention to itself, so that the reader sees through the letters to the meaning. Warde's goblet is the typographic doctrine of diaphanocracy. It demands that the medium vanish before the message, as the Guild demands that the face vanish before the mind. Bester's typography violates the doctrine at every point. It makes the medium visible; it requires the eye to look at the page before reading through it; it gives the text a face in a novel whose world has rendered faces superfluous.

This is the formal conclusion toward which the dissertation's reading has been moving. The content of *The Demolished Man* dreams of transparency: a world in which minds are read without mediation and in which the opaque remainder is consumed by a commons that loves it. The form of *The Demolished Man* insists on opacity: names that cannot be spoken, a numeral struck through, a jingle that cannot be read past, a page that must be seen. In de Man's terms, the typography is the novel's prosopopoeia of itself—the face the text confers upon its own surface—and that face is the novel's unacknowledged defense of the right that its plot appears to abolish. The form remembers what the content forgets.

8.4 *Velocity, Reception, Afterlives*

Bester's prose is kinetic: exclamatory, telegraphic, onomatopoeic, cut like a film and paced like a radio serial. Its velocity belongs to Reich, whose drive sets the tempo, while the deliberation of Powell's investigation repeatedly brakes it; the rhythm of the novel is itself a duel between the speed of the sovereign will and the patience of analysis. Contemporary reviewers greeted the result with superlatives. Groff Conklin, in *Galaxy*, called it a magnificent novel and as fascinating a study of character as he had read; Anthony Boucher and J. Francis McComas, in *The Magazine of Fantasy and Science Fiction*, praised it as "a masterful compounding of science and detective fiction"; Damon Knight later counted it among the ten best science-fiction books of the decade. Later readers have divided precisely along the line this dissertation has drawn. Jo Walton has compared the novel's dependence on Freud to the dependence of C. S. Lewis's *The Last Battle* on Christianity, observing that its resolution makes sense only within the doctrine; Richard Beard, otherwise an admirer, judged Reich's motives stiffly dependent on Freudian theory and the novel blind to anything resembling feminism.

Walton's comparison is more exact than it may intend. A fiction whose resolution is intelligible only within a doctrine is a fiction in which the doctrine functions as theology, which is why the political-theological registers developed in the preceding chapters are not imposed upon the novel but solicited by it.

The afterlives have been unusually various. A German radio adaptation produced by RIAS Berlin in 1973 under the title *Demolition* is reported to have been the first radio drama recorded with a binaural dummy head—an apt technology for a fiction about hearing inside other heads. Brian De Palma has long contemplated a film adaptation; Donald Fagen has suggested that the "expanding man" of Steely Dan's "Deacon Blues" may owe something to the novel; Orion's SF Masterworks series canonized it in 1999. Critics have long identified in Bester's corporate futures and hyperkinetic style a proto-cyberpunk sensibility. And the Psi Corps of *Babylon 5*, with its officer named for the author, is, as Chapter Three observed, the Guild after the Pledge has been forgotten. A novel that imagined the routinization of telepathic charisma has itself been routinized into the mythology of a franchise, and its afterlife confirms its thesis: the institutions survive; the Pledge does not.

CONCLUSION



Theses on the Post-Facial Condition

The Demolished Man is the founding fable of diaphanocracy and the first systematic image of the post-facial condition, and its buried normative claim is a right to the face. In Fredric Jameson's terms (*The Political Unconscious*, 1981), the novel's psychoanalytic unconscious is the vehicle of its political unconscious: the case history of a parricide encodes the transfer of sovereignty from capital to a commons that reads minds. Darko Suvin's poetics of cognitive estrangement (*Metamorphoses of Science Fiction*, 1979), which requires that a fiction's novum be validated by cognitive logic, has always sat uneasily with psionic premises. The present reading suggests that telepathy in Bester is a socio-cognitive novum, whose cognitive content lies not in physics but in social theory, and whose predictive force has grown even as the physics has remained fantastic. The argument may be condensed, in the manner of Benjamin's theses on the concept of history (written 1940), into ten propositions.

I **Transparency relocates violence.** Diaphanocracy abolishes intentional crime by abolishing the privacy of intention. It does not abolish violence; it relocates it into the unconscious of the subject, into the genealogy that formed the subject, and into the rites by which the transparent order disposes of what it cannot read. The seventy-nine years without murder are a latency, not a cure, and the first murder after them is the return of a founding violence in its original, parricidal form.

II **Opacity is conserved.** In any order that renders the contents of minds legible, the irreducibly opaque migrates from content to form—to the relations, genealogies, and structures that constitute minds—and returns as crime without a knowable author. Old Man Mose demands a passion that no conscious mind possesses. The

present supplies the analogue: harms produced by systems—discriminatory classification, cascading financial risk, the emergent effects of automated decision—whose authors cannot be found because no one intended them, and before which a jurisprudence of intent stands as Mose stood before Reich, demanding a motive that is nowhere to be read.

III **Prosopocide is the founding act.** The effacement of the face is the founding act of the post-facial order; murder, telepathy, and Demolition are its criminal, structural, and juridical modalities. Its contemporary form is the conversion of the face from an address into an identifier. Facial recognition reads the face not as the expression of someone who addresses us but as a biometric template that unlocks a record. Bester anticipated the logic: Reich's safe opens only to the pore-pattern of a fingertip that the novel calls irreproducible (DM ch. 1, p. 23), the same word its prologue uses for the megalomaniac's illusion of uniqueness. In Levinas's vocabulary, the face that signified the commandment not to kill has become a key to a file; in de Man's, the prosopopoeia that conferred a face has become the de-facement that takes one away.

IV **The commons becomes the father.** A transparent fraternity re-founds paternal authority by unmaking the son. The commons that forbids murder assumes custody of the murderer and of the murdered man's daughter, and becomes, through therapeutic violence, the parent of the persons it remakes. Every institution that claims custody of the subjects it reshapes—the clinic, the re-education program, the platform that nudges its users toward preferred behaviors—reenacts this structure, and each presents its paternity as care.

V **The death penalty survives for persons.** Diaphanocracy abolishes capital punishment for bodies and retains it for persons: by the Lockean criterion of personal identity, Demolition is an execution. Having made faces superfluous as media of knowledge, the post-facial polity must manufacture persons; it becomes a factory of faces, practicing re-facement. The "data double" that Kevin Haggerty and Richard Ericson identified in "The Surveillant Assemblage" (2000)—a profile assembled from a person's traces that then acts in the world in that person's name—is re-facement without Demolition: the person is not erased but supplemented by a manufactured face that institutions trust more than the original. A single biographical fact compresses the genealogy of this thesis. Zamyatin's *We*, the founding fiction of the glass society, first appeared in print in 1924 in the English translation of Gregory Zilboorg, who became one of the most prominent psychoanalysts in New York and who published, the year after Bester's novel appeared as a book, *The Psychology of the Criminal Act and Punishment* (1954); the first complete Russian edition of *We* ap-

peared, also in New York, in 1952. The translator of the transparent society became a theorist of therapeutic punishment, and Bester's novel stands at the crossing of his two careers.

VI **Privacy survives as noise.** In diaphanocracy the last enclosure is the commodity: Reich's jingle, a product of the culture industry, is the only privacy left to him. Its descendants are encryption, which secures a message by rendering it indistinguishable from noise, and the adversarial cosmetics of Adam Harvey's *CV Dazzle* (2010), which defeat face-detection algorithms with patterns named for the dazzle camouflage painted on warships in the First World War. The paradox Bester saw has become a design principle: the defense of interiority is entrusted to the very forms—repetition, noise, the mass-produced pattern—that the critique of culture held responsible for interiority's destruction. Bester also saw the other refuge, mediation: the telepathic pattern cannot travel by telephone, and Reich thanks God for the phone as the last protection from mind readers (DM ch. 1, p. 22).

VII **Asymmetry is the political question.** Bester's transparency is asymmetrical: Espers read normals, and normals cannot read Espers. His utopianism rests entirely on the Pledge that binds the readers—the Guild's discretion and its prohibition on betraying what it reads. The surveillance economy of the twenty-first century has preserved the asymmetry and dispensed with the Pledge. We have built the Peepers without the Pledge. The first juridical attempts to write a Pledge for the post-facial era—Chile's constitutional amendment of 2021 protecting mental integrity and the activity of the brain, and the neural-data provisions that have since entered other privacy statutes—are, in Bester's terms, efforts to bind a guild that does not yet know it is one. Bester's Guild understood the stakes of its own monopoly: it walls its elite in stone houses, forbids its members to speculate, and, when the crisis comes, forbids exclusive private practice in the name of the most good for the most people (DM chs. 3, 7, 14).

VIII **The eschaton has a price.** Telepathy is the secular realization of Paul's "face to face," and the Man With No Face testifies that the eschaton cannot be immanentized without a sacrificial victim. Eric Voegelin's *The New Science of Politics*, published in 1952, the year of Bester's serialization, diagnosed the modern political religions as Gnostic attempts to realize within history a perfection proper to its end. Diaphanocracy is the gentlest of such immanentizations, and therefore the most persuasive; its gentleness is precisely what conceals its price. The mass cathexis is a Pentecost that requires a victim, and the theodicy of transparency—the justification of a seeing community to the remainder it cannot see—is complete only when the remainder has been erased.

IX **Love requires opacity.** The novel binds transparency to love, as Paul did; but the love it can imagine must be certified as transparent, and Barbara's latent telepathy is the certificate. Byung-Chul Han has argued that eros requires the negativity of an Other who cannot be reduced to the same (*Agonie des Eros*, 2012); Levinas located the ethical relation in an alterity that knowledge cannot exhaust; Édouard Glissant, in *Poétique de la Relation* (1990), claimed for everyone a right to opacity against the Western demand to comprehend the Other—to grasp, as the etymology of *comprendre* has it, what ought instead to be met. Bester's final image—love declared in the shadow of an erased man, by a reader of minds to a woman he has helped to rebuild—asks whether love survives transparency. The novel answers yes. Its central figure answers otherwise. And the novel's own love story stages the alternative before closing it off: Barbara, a normal, reads Powell's lie in his face, and Powell can declare his love only through a telepathic test that converts her into one of the Guild (DM chs. 15, 17).

X **There is a right to the face.** The buried normative claim of *The Demolished Man* is a right to the face: the ethical opacity without which punishment, love, and personhood cease to be intelligible. Punishment requires an agent who owns the deed and a forensic person continuous with the one who committed it; Hegel's dignity of the criminal and Locke's forensic person alike presuppose a self that cannot simply be rewritten. Love requires an Other who is not exhaustively known. Personhood, as Mauss's genealogy of the *persona* recalls, was born as a face. The right to the face is not a right to conceal crime. It is the right to remain the author of one's own disclosure—Simmel's discretion raised from an ethic to a right: the right to be met as a face rather than read as a content. Powell's speech to the Commissioner states the right as a consolation—be grateful that you see only the outward man—and Powell disowns it within the page as a useful line; the novel's last speech demands instead that the veils be torn away (DM ch. 17, pp. 233, 239). The right to the face is the claim the novel can make only in the mouth of its most accomplished liar.

In 1952 Alfred Bester imagined a society that could read every mind, and discovered that what it could not read was the relation between a son and the face of his father. The present is assembling that society piece by piece—in the camera that identifies, the model that predicts, the decoder that reconstructs language from recordings of the brain—without the Pledge that made Bester's version bearable and without the love that made it, on his account, worth its price. The Man With No Face is no longer a figure of nightmare. It is an interface. The task the novel bequeaths is the one its typography performs and its plot forgets: to restore a face to that interface, and to defend the opacity that allows a person to be someone rather than something read.

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KEYWORDS

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